Debt Capacity and the Anatomy of Sovereign Crises*

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Abstract

Sovereign defaults are rarely complete: governments withhold part of their debt service, the missed payments accumulate as arrears, and borrowing continues. We study the partial default model of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) in continuous time and find that it changes the account of how sovereign debt crises begin, unfold, and end. Withholding debt service raises funds at a price fixed by the recovery on arrears, a haircut that existing creditors bear, so a sovereign's debt capacity is set in closed form by the cost of defaulting and not by its patience, its risk aversion, or how much it values market access. Default episodes are triggered by shocks that overwhelm a precautionary buffer, and they begin with a jump whose size the default costs pin down. Once an episode has begun, it is a financing regime: the sovereign keeps borrowing, adding more to its debt through new issues than through arrears, and the regime ends when output recovers rather than when the debt is repaid. Pessimism alone can bring on a slow-moving default, without a run. Formulating the model in continuous time makes it tractable and pays off in computation: the equilibrium is computed quickly and accurately, without the smoothing shocks that discrete-time models rely on, and it fits the data at least as well as the original discrete-time formulation.

Keywords: sovereign debt, partial default, arrears, debt capacity, self-fulfilling crises
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1 Introduction

Sovereign defaults are rarely complete. Governments in distress typically continue to service some of their obligations while suspending payments on others, the missed payments accumulate as arrears that add to the stock of debt, and countries often emerge from a default episode owing more than when it began. Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) document these facts and build a theory of *partial default* around them. In their theory, a sovereign chooses, period by period, what share of its debt service to withhold, at an output cost that rises with the share withheld. It never loses access to the market, where the price of its bonds reflects the default intensity lenders expect. Their framework replaces the binary default decision of the standard model, introduced by Eaton and Gersovitz (1981) and quantified by Arellano (2008), with a continuous one, and exclusion from financial markets with continued access. In their data, emerging economies are in partial default about a third of the time and withhold about forty percent of the debt service when they are. Their calibrated model reproduces the frequency, the depth, and the dynamics of these episodes. We regard partial default as the right description of sovereign distress and the natural baseline for the quantitative theory of sovereign debt.

This paper asks what the partial default model teaches about the economics of sovereign crises, and finds four lessons. The limit on a sovereign's debt is set by the cost of defaulting, not by the value the sovereign attaches to market access. Defaults begin with a jump, whose size the cost structure fixes, and they are triggered by shocks that overwhelm a precautionary buffer rather than by borrowing into default. Once a crisis episode has begun, the economy is in a financing regime in which the sovereign keeps borrowing, and the episode ends when output recovers rather than when the debt is repaid. Pessimism alone can produce a slow crisis, without a run or loss of market access. We draw our lessons from three versions of the model. The first has a constant endowment, where a sharp characterization in closed form is possible. The second puts the endowment on a Markov chain, which adds precautionary behavior. The third has a diffusion calibrated to the targets of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023). We write the model in continuous time, where the default intensity is a flow decision and arrears accrue continuously. We find it especially tractable: the sovereign never loses market access, so there is no stopping problem, and given the bond price the default decision is static.

The first lesson concerns the determinants of the sovereign's debt limit. In the binary model, the limit is the outcome of the whole dynamic problem. It is the debt at which the value of staying in the market no longer covers repayment, and it depends on the sovereign's patience, on its risk aversion, and on the punishment that follows a default. Under partial default, the limit reflects a static comparison. Withholding a unit of debt service raises consumption by one minus the market value of the arrears it creates, at the cost of lost output (Lemma 1). Withholding is a source of funds whose price is fixed by the recovery on arrears, a haircut that existing creditors bear, and not by the market. Our analysis makes exact the description by Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) of partial default as a flexible way to raise funds. It also explains why arrears are attractive precisely when market prices are low: the terms of this source of

funds do not deteriorate with the sovereign's creditworthiness. Given debt, the endowment, and the price, the share withheld maximizes a resource function that is concave away from zero default and depends neither on the value function nor on the direction in which debt is moving (Proposition 1). So the regions of no, partial, and full default are explicit in the state and the price (Proposition 2 and Figure 2). In the deterministic model the impatient sovereign borrows at the risk-free bond price up to the largest debt it is willing to service in full and stops there, because one more unit would start a default that the price would charge for. Its debt capacity is the no-default threshold at the risk-free price (Theorem 1). This capacity is a closed-form function of the default costs, of the recovery on arrears, and of the maturity of the debt, independent of the sovereign's impatience, its risk aversion, and the borrowing limit. Preferences decide whether a sovereign goes to its limit, but the cost of defaulting decides where the limit is.[1]

The second lesson is about how defaults begin. A sovereign never defaults a little. Although the intensity is a continuous choice, a fixed cost makes entry into default lumpy: the first default is a jump whose size the endowment and the cost parameters alone determine (Proposition 2). At the calibrated parameters it is half of the debt service. The fixed cost makes full repayment possible, since without it the first unit withheld has zero marginal cost and the sovereign defaults a little at every positive debt. A steep variable cost then makes the jump large. Explaining what triggers the jump requires uncertainty, which the chain model adds with a single new element, precaution. In a state that can switch to a worse one, the sovereign can hold its debt below its threshold when the loss from arriving in a worse state with more debt is large enough. Its buffer is then set by an Euler equation that balances the impatience gain from borrowing against that loss (Proposition 5). Otherwise, and always in the state with the lowest consumption, the sovereign borrows to its edge. A second force works through prices. Beyond the threshold of a worse state that one switch can reach, a switch triggers an immediate default, so the price schedule of the better state has a kink there. In nearly all the two-state chains we computed, the kink holds the better state at or below the worse state's threshold, with no default in the ergodic set. Default occurs when a shock moves the threshold below the sovereign's current debt, further than its buffer guards against. Such a shock is a rare jump to a much worse state in the chain model, or the continuum of shocks of the diffusion model, where the threshold moves continuously with the endowment and the sovereign is caught on the wrong side of it. How often a sovereign defaults depends on how the tail of its shocks compares with the buffer it holds, not on a willingness to borrow into default.

The third lesson speaks to the nature of default episodes. In the binary model a sovereign past its limit defaults, and the adjustment is a jump into exclusion or renegotiation. Under partial default the adjustment is gradual, and in the deterministic model we characterize it exactly. Above its capacity the sovereign is in partial default, the price is below par, and it repays, but at a speed that vanishes like the cube root of the excess debt, while the price leaves par with a vertical

1. Amador and Phelan (2021, 2023) develop the reputational theory of sovereign default. The latter does so in a setting with partial default, the closest theoretical treatment of a partial default decision we know of.

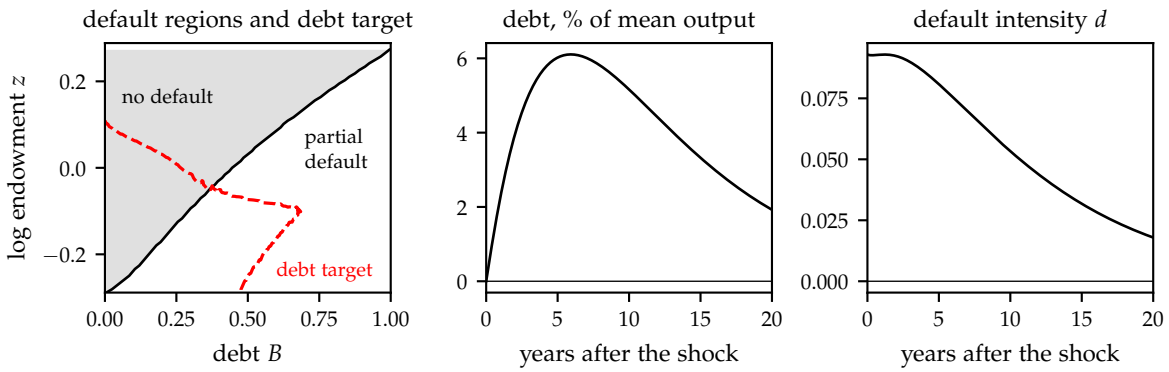


Figure 1: The anatomy of a crisis in the calibrated model. Left: the no-default region (shaded), bounded by the default threshold, and the debt target, the locus where the drift of debt vanishes. In good times the target lies inside the no-default region, and in bad times inside the partial-default region. Center and right: the responses of debt and of the default intensity to a fall of 0.10 in the log endowment at date zero, from the ergodic distribution (Section 4.3).

tangent (Theorem 2). A sizable excess takes a few years to work off, but even a small excess is visibly priced at once. So a debt overhang is worked off without exclusion or restructuring, and the spread reacts to it before the debt itself moves. From below, the sovereign approaches its capacity along a square-root law and reaches it in finite time (Lemma 2). Bornstein (2020) identifies a painful deleveraging effect specific to settings in which the stock of debt moves slowly. In the partial default model the law of motion of the adjustment is in closed form. With shocks the episode acquires a feature the deterministic model cannot show. Once a bad shock has moved the threshold below the current debt, the fixed cost is being paid regardless and no longer restrains borrowing. The sovereign's debt target is then set by the dilution of its own price, the force that Hatchondo, Martinez, and Sosa-Padilla (2016) show drives default risk with long-term debt. The target is higher than in good times, so the sovereign in partial default borrows. In the calibrated diffusion model, after a fall in output of about one standard deviation the default intensity jumps and stays elevated for a decade, and debt keeps rising for six years (Figure 1). New issues add several times as much to the debt as arrears. Continued market access is the larger cushion against the shock and arrears the smaller, which puts a mechanism and an accounting behind the facts that debt rises during episodes and that countries exit them owing more. The episode ends when output recovers and the threshold rises back above the debt, not when the debt is repaid: default is lumpy at entry and sticky thereafter. Hurtado, Nuño, and Thomas (2023) study the closest mechanism in continuous time, a sovereign that lowers the real value of its local-currency debt through inflation. Inflation acts on the whole stock, whereas partial default acts on the flow of debt service and raises the stock through arrears.

The fourth lesson is that pessimism alone can produce a crisis, and that it unfolds slowly. If lenders expect the sovereign to settle at a debt typically above its capacity and to withhold a constant share of its debt service there forever, they price the bond accordingly. At the lower price withholding is cheaper, so the sovereign starts defaulting at debt levels at which it would

otherwise have repaid. It can also borrow past its old capacity, because the default is priced and the funds it raises cost it only the risk-free rate. With curvature it drifts into a permanent partial default over years, through new issues and arrears, and the arrears validate the price. There is no run and no loss of market access. This is the slow-moving crisis of Lorenzoni and Werning (2019) with arrears in the place of rollover, and the self-fulfilling dilution of Aguiar and Amador (2020) with a continuous default decision. The difference is where the sovereign's willingness to participate enters. In a rollover crisis the sovereign must roll over, whereas here it can stay out of the default region. So a pessimistic expectation is self-fulfilling only if borrowing into default at a discount beats staying out. The candidates form a continuum indexed by the intensity of the permanent default, and whether one is an equilibrium is a two-point problem, the sovereign's willingness to borrow into default all the way from zero debt. For a risk-neutral sovereign we nearly solve it: a self-fulfilling partial default can be reached from zero debt only if the gain from front-loading the borrowed funds covers the output cost of the cheapest default. It is an equilibrium when, in addition, the steady state attracts and the price schedule continues regularly above it. When the default cost is not too convex, the threshold is that the impatience wedge exceed the spread implied by the first default (Proposition 4). Risk aversion works against the crisis, because a sovereign that values smooth consumption gains less from front-loading. In a numerical example a relative risk aversion of two roughly triples the impatience that a pessimistic expectation needs to be self-fulfilling, and the requirement falls toward its risk-neutral value as the curvature falls. Uncertainty works against the crisis too. With shocks, the range of impatience that supports a self-fulfilling partial default narrows as volatility rises, and it closes at moderate volatility (Figure 4). A lower bound on the price of new issues rules such equilibria out whenever the spread implied by the first default exceeds the spread at the bound (Proposition 3). At the calibrated parameters it does, narrowly, and the impatience wedge is in any case far below the threshold.

The quantitative section calibrates the diffusion model to the same moments that Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) target, with their free parameters and their weights, and it fits them at least as well under their own loss. The thresholds and the debt capacity of the theory are visible in the policies: the no-default region is a wedge that rises with the endowment, and the default intensity jumps to the first default at its edge. The ergodic distribution concentrates on the locus where debt is stationary, and the shape of that locus, the debt target of Figure 1, reflects the first three lessons at once. In good times the target lies below capacity, held there by precaution. As output falls the target rises, since the sovereign is in partial default and borrows against its diluted price. In the worst states, more than one standard deviation below the mean, the price of new issues reaches the bound and the target falls back. Spreads are low most of the time and high in the tail, and they track output and debt more tightly than in the data, since the model has no shocks on the lenders' side. Defaulted coupons in default are lower and less volatile than in the data, as in the discrete-time model.

Two further contributions are technical. The first is computational. The equilibrium of the

stochastic models is computed by an implicit upwind scheme in the tradition of Achdou et al. (2022), and the default decision needs no smoothing. Discrete-time models with long-term debt rely on i.i.d. shocks, to income or to the default and borrowing choices, to make the price schedule converge (Chatterjee and Eyigungor 2012; Dvorkin et al. 2021; Mihalache 2020). These devices are widely used and effective, yet the smoothed decision is not the one the model describes, and convergence depends on their scale (see Mihalache (2025) for a survey). In the continuous-time model the default intensity is a continuous control, and the computed decision is the model's own. The long-run distribution and the impulse responses are computed exactly from the generator of the discretized process rather than by simulation.[2] The second concerns the model at high debt. Where default carries no fixed cost, a sovereign in full default faces a marginal cost of debt close to zero while lenders still pay a positive price, so it borrows up to whatever borrowing limit the model imposes. Quantitative models leave the limit implicit, as the top of the debt grid, so a choice about the computation becomes part of the model. We make the limit explicit and adopt an underwriting standard, a lower bound on the price of new issues as in Chatterjee and Eyigungor (2015), under which the level of the limit is irrelevant (Section 3.2). Hatchondo, Martinez, and Roch (2022) study a related rule, a spread brake that caps the deficit when the sovereign spread exceeds a threshold. At the calibrated parameters the standard binds on less than one percent of the ergodic mass, and its main visible effect is to set the debt target in the worst states.

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 presents the model and its HJB and pricing equations, defines the equilibrium, and discusses the key assumptions, including the borrowing limit and the underwriting standard. Section 3 characterizes the equilibrium analytically wherever possible. Section 4 contains the quantitative analysis of the diffusion model: calibration, computation, policies, the ergodic distribution, and the impulse responses. Section 5 concludes. The appendices contain additional theoretical results, proofs, the numerical implementation of all models, and robustness checks.

2 The Partial Default Model

The economy consists of a small open economy governed by a risk-averse sovereign and of a unit measure of competitive, risk-neutral international lenders. Time is continuous. We describe the two problems in turn and define the equilibrium.

2. Bornstein (2020) finds that computation is faster in continuous time in the binary model. Rendahl (2022) discusses the extent to which similar results can be obtained in discrete time by adapting the sparse matrix methods at the core of the continuous-time solution. Tourre (2017) studies the binary model in continuous time with recursive utility and a rich pricing kernel. Aguiar et al. (2019) study default and debt maturity in continuous time, and DeMarzo, He, and Tourre (2023) a sovereign that cannot commit to a debt path. These papers solve optimal stopping problems with HJB variational inequalities, because default is a discrete transition into exclusion. The partial default model has no such transition, which is the source of its tractability.

2.1 The Sovereign's Problem

The sovereign receives an endowment stream, borrows abroad with long-term bonds, and chooses at every instant what fraction of its scheduled debt service to pay. The part of the debt service it does not pay accrues as arrears and adds to the stock of debt.

Preferences and endowment. The sovereign maximizes

$$\mathbb{E}_0 \int_0^\infty e^{-\rho t}\, u(c_t)\, dt,$$

where ρ is its discount rate and u is increasing and strictly concave. The log endowment z_t follows a Markov process with generator $\mathcal{L}_z$, which we leave general in this section: in Section 3 it is constant or a finite-state chain, in Section 4 an Ornstein–Uhlenbeck diffusion. We call the model with a general Markov process the *general model*, and its three special cases the *deterministic model* (constant endowment), the *chain model* (a finite-state Markov chain), and the *diffusion model* (an Ornstein–Uhlenbeck diffusion). Output is e^{z_t} when the sovereign is current on its debt. When it defaults, output is $\phi(d_t, z_t)\, e^{z_t}$, where the cost function ϕ is described below.

Debt. The stock of debt is B_t. Each unit of debt pays a coupon λ and matures at rate δ, so that the scheduled debt service is $(\delta + \lambda)B_t$ per unit of time.[3] The sovereign chooses a *default intensity* $d_t \in [0, 1]$, the share of the scheduled debt service it withholds. Of every unit withheld, a fraction κ is added to the stock of debt as arrears. The fraction $1 - \kappa$ is the haircut suffered by lenders on defaulted payments. The sovereign also issues ℓ_t units of new debt at the market price q_t (when $\ell_t < 0$ it buys debt back). The budget constraint and the law of motion of debt are

$$c_t = \phi(d_t, z_t)\, e^{z_t} - (1 - d_t)(\delta + \lambda)B_t + q_t\, \ell_t, \tag{1}$$

$$\dot{B}_t = \ell_t - \delta B_t + \kappa(\delta + \lambda)\, d_t\, B_t. \tag{2}$$

The three terms in (1) are income net of the default cost, the part of the debt service that is paid, and the proceeds from issuance. The three terms in (2) are issuance, amortization, and the accrual of arrears. It is convenient to write

$$a(d) := \delta - \kappa(\delta + \lambda)\, d, \qquad a := a(1) = \delta - \kappa(\delta + \lambda),$$

so that $\dot{B}_t = \ell_t - a(d_t)B_t$: absent issuance, debt decays at rate $a(d)$, which is lowest in full default. We assume $a > 0$, so that even a sovereign in full default sees its debt shrink, slowly, when it does not issue. Debt is bounded, $B_t \in [0, \bar{B}]$: the sovereign does not lend, and, as in every incomplete-markets model, a borrowing limit $\bar{B}$ rules out Ponzi schemes. Quantitative default

3. This is the continuous-time counterpart of the long-term bond of Hatchondo and Martinez (2009) and Chatterjee and Eyigungor (2012). The maturing fraction δ of the stock is repaid at par, and a single state variable summarizes the debt.

models usually leave the limit implicit, as the top of the grid on which debt is computed. We make it explicit because, without the underwriting standard of Section 2.4, its level matters.

The cost of default. Following Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) the cost of default has a variable and a fixed component,

$$\phi(d,z) = (1-\gamma_0 d^{\gamma_1})\,F(z) \;\text{ for } d>0, \qquad \phi(0,z)=1, \qquad F(z) = 1-\gamma_2\,(e^z-y^*)\,\mathbb{1}\{e^z \geq y^*\}, \tag{3}$$

with $\gamma_0 \in (0,1)$, $\gamma_1 > 1$, and $\gamma_2 \geq 0$. The variable cost $\gamma_0 d^{\gamma_1}$ is convex in the default intensity with zero marginal cost at $d=0$. The fixed cost $(1-F(z))e^z$ is paid whenever the sovereign defaults at all, however little, and only when output e^z exceeds the threshold y^*. The fixed cost is larger in better times. Below the threshold default carries only the variable cost, and we call these states the *no-fixed-cost region*. The jump of ϕ at $d=0$ above the threshold creates a region of no default: a small default is not worth its fixed cost.

The drift of debt. Substituting ℓ_t out of (1) using (2), the drift of debt is a function of the state, the price, and the two controls,

$$S(B,z,c,d,q) = \frac{c-\phi(d,z)e^z+(1-d)(\delta+\lambda)B}{q} - a(d)\,B,$$

and we treat consumption c and the default intensity d as the controls. Equivalently, for a given drift S,

$$c = \mathcal{R}(d;B,z,q) + q\,S, \qquad \mathcal{R}(d;B,z,q) := \phi(d,z)e^z - (1-d)(\delta+\lambda)B + q\,a(d)\,B. \tag{4}$$

We call $\mathcal{R}$ the *resource function*: it is consumption at zero drift, and it is all that the default decision affects for a given drift. The characterization of Section 3 rests on this decomposition.

Arrears as borrowing. The decomposition has a second reading, which makes exact the description of partial default by Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) as a flexible way to raise funds. Let $n_t := \ell_t + \kappa(\delta+\lambda)d_t B_t$ be the total addition to the stock of debt, from issuance and from arrears, so that $\dot{B}_t = n_t - \delta B_t$. Substituting into (1),

$$c_t = \phi(d_t,z_t)e^{z_t} - (\delta+\lambda)B_t + q_t\,n_t + (1-\kappa q_t)(\delta+\lambda)B_t\,d_t. \tag{5}$$

Holding the path of debt fixed, withholding a unit of debt service raises consumption by $1-\kappa q_t > 0$: the unit saved, net of the market value of the κ units of arrears that replace market issuance one for one. Equivalently, withholding raises funds at the implicit price $1/\kappa$ per unit of arrears, which exceeds the market price and does not depend on it, paid for with the output cost $(1-\phi)e^z$ of default. Section 3.1 draws the consequences.

The HJB equation. Given a bond price function $q(B,z)$, the sovereign's value $V(B,z)$ solves

$$\rho V(B,z) = \max_{c,\ d\in[0,1]} \{u(c) + S(B,z,c,d,q(B,z))\, V_B(B,z) + \mathcal{L}_z V(B,z)\}, \tag{6}$$

subject to the state constraints $0 \le B \le \bar{B}$ and the underwriting standard of Section 2.4. Subscripts denote partial derivatives. The derivation is in Appendix A. Unlike in models with a binary default decision, there is no variational inequality and no second regime: the sovereign never loses market access, and a single value function with possibly discontinuous policies describes it at all states.

First-order conditions. At an interior drift, consumption satisfies

$$u'(c)\, q(B,z) = -V_B(B,z), \tag{7}$$

the price of a bond times the marginal utility of the resources it brings equals the marginal cost of debt in utility units. By (4) the default intensity enters the objective only through $\mathcal{R}$, which is strictly concave on $(0,1]$ with

$$\mathcal{R}_d(d) = -\gamma_0\gamma_1 F(z) e^z d^{\gamma_1 - 1} + (1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)B.$$

The marginal gain from raising the default intensity is $(1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)B$: the payment saved, net of the market value κq of the arrears it creates. The interior maximizer is

$$d_{\text{int}}(B,z,q) = \min\left\{1,\ \left[\frac{(1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)B}{\gamma_0\gamma_1 F(z) e^z}\right]^{1/(\gamma_1-1)}\right\}, \tag{8}$$

and the optimal default intensity is either 0 or d_{int}, whichever gives the larger resource function. Section 3.1 makes this precise and shows that it holds for every maximizer of (6) wherever the underwriting standard is slack.

2.2 International Lenders

A unit measure of deep-pocketed, competitive, risk-neutral lenders with outside option r buy and hold the sovereign's bonds. A unit of debt held at t yields the flow $(1-d_t)(\delta+\lambda)$ in cash and $\kappa(\delta+\lambda)d_t$ in new units (the arrears), and δ of it matures. The break-even price is the expected discounted value of the cash flow, where the discount rate is adjusted for the growth of the position through arrears,

$$q(B,z) = \mathbb{E}_{B,z} \int_0^\infty \exp\left(-\int_0^t \xi(d_s)\, ds\right) (1-d_t)(\lambda+\delta)\, dt, \qquad \xi(d) := r + \delta - \kappa(\delta+\lambda)\, d. \tag{9}$$

The effective discount rate $\xi(d)$ combines the lenders' opportunity cost r, the amortization δ, and the accrual of arrears, which lowers it. By the Feynman–Kac formula, q solves the linear equation

$$\xi(d(B,z))\, q(B,z) = (1 - d(B,z))(\lambda + \delta) + \tilde{S}(B,z)\, q_B(B,z) + \mathcal{L}_z q(B,z), \tag{10}$$

where $\tilde{S}(B,z)$ is the equilibrium drift of debt and $d(B,z)$ the equilibrium default policy. The evolution of the stock of debt is governed by $\tilde{S}$, which includes issuance. The cash flow of a single unit is governed by $\xi(d)$, which does not.

Spreads and duration. The price of a bond that never defaults, the *risk-free price*, is $q^{\mathrm{rf}} = (\delta + \lambda)/(r + \delta)$. We set the coupon equal to the risk-free rate, $\lambda = r$, so that $q^{\mathrm{rf}} = 1$ and the face value of a bond equals its risk-free value. We keep the symbol q^{rf} wherever a price is the risk-free one. The yield to maturity implied by a price q is $(\delta + \lambda)/q - \delta$, so the spread over the risk-free yield is

$$\mathrm{spread}(B,z) = \frac{\delta + \lambda}{q(B,z)} - (\delta + r),$$

and the risk-free Macaulay duration of the bond is $1/(\delta + r)$.

2.3 Equilibrium and the Ergodic Set

Definition 1. A *Markov equilibrium* consists of a value function $V(B,z)$, policies $c(B,z)$ and $d(B,z)$, and a bond price $q(B,z)$ such that

1. given q, the value V solves the HJB equation (6) and (c,d) attain the maximum on its right-hand side, subject to the state constraints $0 \le B \le \bar{B}$ and the underwriting standard of Section 2.4;

2. given the policies, q solves the pricing equation (10), equivalently (9).

The stationary distribution. Let $g(B,z)$ be the density of the state. Given the equilibrium drift $\tilde{S}$ and the generator $\mathcal{L}_z$ with adjoint $\mathcal{L}_z^*$, the density solves the Kolmogorov forward equation

$$\partial_t g = -\partial_B \left[\tilde{S}(B,z)\, g\right] + \mathcal{L}_z^* g, \tag{11}$$

and the stationary distribution solves $0 = -\partial_B[\tilde{S} g] + \mathcal{L}_z^* g$. The forward equation is the adjoint of the HJB equation: in the discretized model the same sparse matrix that solves the HJB equation, transposed, gives the stationary distribution, so that the long-run moments are available without simulation (Appendix B). The stationary distribution can have atoms: at $B = 0$ when the sovereign repays in full at a high endowment, and at stationary points of debt in the deterministic and chain models. We call its support the *ergodic set*. Its shape, in particular how far it extends into the default region, is a central object of the paper.

2.4 The Underwriting Standard

Without a further restriction the borrowing limit $B \leq \bar{B}$ is not innocuous. In the states where default carries no fixed cost, a sovereign in full default faces almost no marginal cost of debt while lenders still pay a positive price, because output will recover. So, as we argue in Section 3.2, the sovereign issues at any positive price and borrows up to the limit, whatever its level. We therefore impose an *underwriting standard*: the banks that underwrite the sovereign's issues in the financial centers do not bring a new issue to market at a price below a floor $\underline{q}$,

$$\ell_t \leq 0 \quad \text{whenever} \quad q(B_t, z_t) < \underline{q}. \tag{12}$$

The restriction is on placements, not on holdings: the outstanding bonds continue to trade at the price q that competitive lenders set, buybacks remain allowed, and partial default and the accrual of arrears are unchanged. A lower bound of this kind on the price of new issues appears in Chatterjee and Eyigungor (2015). In yield terms, with $\lambda = r$ the floor corresponds to a spread of $(\delta + \lambda)(1/\underline{q} - 1)$. For the value $\underline{q} = 0.6$ we use, this is about 1,280 basis points at the calibrated maturity rate. The level is a judgment: at the calibrated parameters it lies far above the highest price at which the unconstrained sovereign issues in full default, about 0.3 (Appendix C). The restriction is on the price rather than on the quantity of debt because the accumulation is located by the price. The accumulation begins at the full-default line in the states where default carries no fixed cost, at debt levels that differ across states. A floor on the price is a state-dependent debt limit expressed in the one variable both parties observe, the underwriters' counterpart of the spread brakes that Hatchondo, Martinez, and Roch (2022) study as fiscal rules. The standard makes the full-default region transient and the level of the borrowing limit $\bar{B}$ irrelevant, assuming the limit exceeds the full-default thresholds. It also bounds the support of debt, and where it binds it makes the sovereign apply its default rule at a shadow price below the market price. It binds only in deep distress: at the calibrated parameters, on just under one percent of the ergodic mass, all of it more than one standard deviation below the mean endowment.

No trade at a zero price. A second, milder convention rules out the autarky equilibrium in which lenders expect full default forever, the price is zero, and the sovereign keeps itself above the full-default line by issuing at a zero price. We impose that no bonds change hands at a zero price. Section 3.1 shows that the price is then strictly positive at every state.

3 Characterization

This section collects what can be established analytically, organized around the questions behind the four lessons of the introduction. Section 3.1 contains the results for the general model, any Markov endowment process: the arrears identity, the static default decision and the thresholds, and the bond price and the value. Section 3.2 turns to high debt, where the model needs the bor-

rowing limit and the underwriting standard. Section 3.3 specializes to the deterministic model, where the closed-form results live: debt capacity in closed form, the laws of motion on either side of it, and self-fulfilling partial default. Section 3.4 treats the chain model. Proofs, and the more technical results, are in Appendix A. Everything else in this section is one of two other kinds of statement, marked as such: an argument, which explains a mechanism without proving it, or a numerical finding, which names the model and the parameters it was computed at. The numerical illustrations of the deterministic and chain models borrow the parameters of the diffusion model's calibration (Table 1), with the endowment held at its mean or at a few fixed levels. The exception is Figure 3, a numerical example with parameter values of its own. Throughout we maintain the following.

Assumption 1.

(i) $a = \delta - \kappa(\delta + \lambda) > 0$, so that also $\xi(1) = r + a > 0$.

(ii) $\lambda = r$, so that $q^{\mathrm{rf}} = 1$; $\rho > r$.

(iii) u is C^2, strictly increasing, and strictly concave; $\gamma_1 > 1$, $0 < \gamma_0 < 1$, and $F(z) > 0$.

(iv) The drift is bounded above, $S \leq \bar{S}$, consumption is bounded below, $c \geq c_{\min} > 0$, which bounds buybacks, and $B \in [0, \bar{B}]$.

Open questions. Most of our results are simple once the model is written in continuous time. Even so, three questions remain open. The first is existence of the coupled equilibrium in the chain and diffusion models, since the best response from prices to prices is neither continuous nor monotone. The second is its uniqueness. The third is whether self-fulfilling partial-default steady states exist. For the last we have analytic answers in the deterministic model only: a necessary condition under the standard (Proposition 3), and, for a risk-neutral sovereign, conditions that are necessary and, up to an attraction and a continuation condition, sufficient (Proposition 4). With curvature and with shocks we have numerical findings.

3.1 Results for any Markov endowment process

For any Markov endowment process, the default decision is static and its thresholds are explicit. This makes debt capacity a closed form.

Lemma 1 (arrears raise funds at a fixed price)**.** *For any path of the total addition to debt n_t, from issuance and from arrears, consumption satisfies (5). That is, a unit of debt service withheld raises one unit of funds against κ units of arrears, at the implicit price $1/\kappa$, independent of the market price, in exchange for the output cost of default. In particular, for a given drift of debt the default intensity affects consumption only through the resource function $\mathcal{R}(d; B, z, q) = \phi(d, z)e^z - (1 - d)(\delta + \lambda)B + q\,a(d)B$, and $\mathcal{R}_d = -\gamma_0\gamma_1 F(z)e^z d^{\gamma_1 - 1} + (1 - \kappa q)(\delta + \lambda)B$ for $d > 0$.*

The lemma is an identity, and it organizes the model. The sovereign has two ways of raising funds, the market at the price q and arrears at the price $1/\kappa$. The second is always the cheaper per unit of debt but always costs output. Everything below follows from the lemma, starting with the fact that the choice between the two is static.

By the first-order condition $\mathcal{R}_d = 0$, the sovereign withholds until the marginal output cost of default per unit of debt service withheld, $\gamma_0\gamma_1 F(z)e^z d^{\gamma_1-1}/((\delta+\lambda)B)$, equals $1-\kappa q$. The right-hand side is the unit of cash it saves net of the market value of the κ units of arrears it creates. Everything the default policy does follows from this margin. A lower price makes the arrears cheaper, so the sovereign withholds more: intensity rises as the price falls, in the default region of the calibrated model (Section 4.3) and under a pessimistic expectation (Section 3.3). A larger debt raises the cash saved per unit of intensity while the marginal output cost does not depend on debt, so intensity rises with debt. Where the underwriting standard binds, the sovereign values its arrears at its own shadow price, below the market price, and withholds more still (Proposition A.6). The fixed cost decides only whether the sovereign is on this margin at all.

Proposition 1 (the default decision is static)**.** *For every state (B,z), price $q \geq 0$, and value function V, every maximizer (d^*,c^*) of the right-hand side of (6), subject to constraints on the drift that do not depend on d (in particular wherever the underwriting standard is slack), satisfies*

$$d^* \in \arg\max_{d\in[0,1]} \ \mathcal{R}(d;B,z,q).$$

The default policy depends on $(B,z,q(B,z))$ only, and not on V, on the sign of the drift, or on the constraints on the drift, as long as those constraints do not depend on d.

The qualification matters for the underwriting standard, whose constraint $\ell = S + a(d)B \leq 0$ does depend on d. Section 3.2 gives the rule in that case (Proposition A.6). Everywhere else the default decision is a static maximization of the function $\mathcal{R}$, concave on $(0,1]$, which yields explicit thresholds.

Proposition 2 (default thresholds)**.** *In the general model, fix (B,z,q) with $B>0$ and $\kappa q<1$. The optimal default intensity is $d^*=0$ if the fixed cost exceeds the gain from defaulting,*

$$(1-F(z))\,e^z \ \geq \ \Gamma(B,z,q) := (1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)B\,d_{\text{int}} - \gamma_0 F(z)e^z d_{\text{int}}^{\gamma_1}, \tag{13}$$

and $d^* = d_{\text{int}}(B,z,q)$ of (8) otherwise. Γ is continuous, strictly increasing in B, strictly decreasing in q, and zero at $B=0$. Consequently:

(a) there is a threshold $B_{\text{pd}}(z,q)$, nondecreasing in q, with $d^*=0$ for $B \leq B_{\text{pd}}$ and $d^* = d_{\text{int}} > 0$ for $B > B_{\text{pd}}$;

(b) in the no-fixed-cost region ($F(z)=1$), $B_{\text{pd}}(z,q)=0$: any positive debt is partially defaulted on;

(c) if $F(z) < 1$ and $d_{\text{first}}(z) < 1$ (below), the default intensity jumps at B_{pd} from 0 to the first default intensity

$$d_{\text{first}}(z) = \left[\frac{1 - F(z)}{(\gamma_1 - 1)\gamma_0 F(z)}\right]^{1/\gamma_1}, \tag{14}$$

which depends only on the endowment and the cost parameters, not on debt, the price, or preferences;

(d) full default, $d^* = 1$, occurs for $B \geq B_{\text{fd}}(z, q)$ and $B > B_{\text{pd}}(z, q)$, where

$$B_{\text{fd}}(z, q) := \frac{\gamma_0 \gamma_1 F(z) e^z}{(1 - \kappa q)(\delta + \lambda)};$$

when $d_{\text{first}}(z) \geq 1$ the intensity jumps from 0 directly to 1 at B_{pd};

(e) the threshold has a closed form: when $d_{\text{first}} < 1$,

$$B_{\text{pd}}(z, q)^{\frac{\gamma_1}{\gamma_1 - 1}} = \frac{\gamma_1}{\gamma_1 - 1} \frac{(1 - F(z))\, e^z\, G^{\frac{1}{\gamma_1 - 1}}}{K^{\frac{\gamma_1}{\gamma_1 - 1}}}, \qquad G := \gamma_0 \gamma_1 F(z) e^z, \quad K := (1 - \kappa q)(\delta + \lambda), \tag{15}$$

and when $d_{\text{first}} \geq 1$, $B_{\text{pd}}(z, q) = (1 - (1 - \gamma_0) F(z)) e^z / K$.

Two monotonicity properties follow, and both reflect the default margin at work. First, $d^*(B, z, q)$ is nondecreasing in B and nonincreasing in q, in γ_0, in κ, and in $F(z)e^z$ holding the fixed cost $(1 - F(z))e^z$ fixed. Second, the thresholds B_{pd} and B_{fd} are increasing in γ_0, in κ, and in q, decreasing in $\delta + \lambda$, and B_{pd} is increasing in the fixed cost $1 - F(z)$ (using $\gamma_0 < 1$). The thresholds make the regions of default explicit in the primitives and the price, which the discrete-time model obtains only numerically.

The thresholds are stated at a given price. In equilibrium the no-default region is $\{B \leq B_{\text{pd}}(z, q(B, z))\}$, a fixed-point condition, which is explicit at the risk-free price. Two implications follow directly. First, a sovereign never defaults a little. The first default is the jump d_{first}, which depends only on the endowment and the cost parameters. At the calibrated parameters it is half of the debt service, $d_{\text{first}} \approx 0.52$ at the average endowment. The jump is large not because the fixed cost is large but because the variable cost is steep. The jump d_{first} is the ratio of the fixed cost, $1 - F$, to $\gamma_1 - 1$ times the variable cost at full default, $\gamma_0 F$ (both per unit of output), raised to the power $1/\gamma_1$ with $\gamma_1 = 3.1$. Here that ratio is 0.13. The fixed cost is what makes full repayment possible rather than what produces the jump. With $F(z) = 1$ the variable cost has zero marginal cost at $d = 0$, so $\Gamma(B, z, q) > 0$ and (13) fails at every $B > 0$. Then the sovereign defaults a little at every positive debt level, and there is no region of full repayment. Any positive fixed cost restores that region, and a jump at its edge is then the only way to leave it. Second, at the risk-free price the no-default region at the average endowment ends at $B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}}) = 0.485$, which is where the steady state of the deterministic model sits (Theorem 1). So the debt capacity of the partial default model is an explicit function of the primitives. Figure 2 draws both implications at the calibrated parameters.

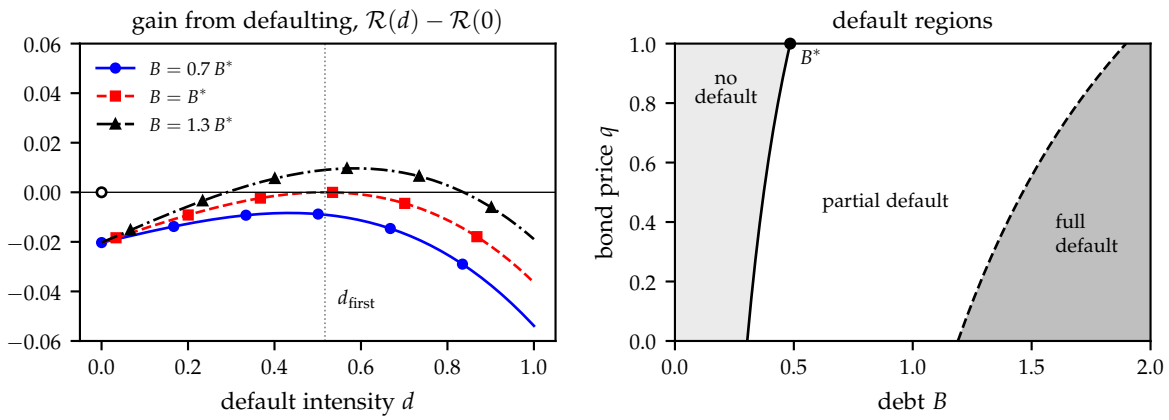


Figure 2: The default decision at the mean endowment, from the closed forms of Proposition 2 at the calibrated parameters. Left: the gain from defaulting at intensity d, $\mathcal{R}(d) - \mathcal{R}(0)$, at the risk-free price and three debt levels. At $d = 0$ the gain is zero (open circle). Any positive intensity pays the fixed cost, so the gain jumps down. At $B = B^*$ the best default, d_{first}, ties with full repayment. Right: the thresholds $B_{\text{pd}}(0, q)$ and $B_{\text{fd}}(0, q)$ divide the (B, q) plane into the regions of no, partial, and full default. The no-default region shrinks as the price falls, and its edge at the risk-free price is the debt capacity $B^* = B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$.

Four further properties of the bond price q and the value V hold in the general model. They are routine, and their statements and proofs are in Appendix A.2. The bond price lies between 0 and q^{rf}. It equals q^{rf} only along paths without default, and 0 only along paths in full default forever (Proposition A.1). The price can jump in debt only at points where debt stops moving and that are not reached in finite time from both sides, and is continuous elsewhere (Proposition A.2). This locates the possible price cliffs of computed solutions. An equilibrium in which lenders expect full default forever and the price is zero exists only on a knife edge. The convention against trade at a zero price removes it, so that the price is strictly positive at every state (Proposition A.3). Finally, when the price is nonincreasing in debt the value is too, with buybacks and with the underwriting standard (Proposition A.4).

3.2 High Debt and the Underwriting Standard

In the no-fixed-cost region a sovereign in full default pays nothing, bears only the variable cost, and faces a marginal cost of debt close to zero, while lenders still pay a positive price because output will recover. By (7) the sovereign issues at any positive price. Without a borrowing limit debt could not stay above every full-default threshold forever, since debt that is never serviced again is worthless (Proposition A.5). With a limit the sovereign borrows up to it, whatever its level, so a parameter that is normally innocuous shapes equilibrium behavior at high debt. The results are in Appendix A.3.

The underwriting standard removes the accumulation. With issuance switched off below $\underline{q}$, debt shrinks in full default, the full-default region is transient, and any borrowing limit above the full-default thresholds is an exact truncation, so that its level is irrelevant (Proposition A.7). The

long-run distribution of debt is confined to the debt levels at which the price can still reach the floor (Proposition A.8). The thresholds of Proposition 2, as functions of the state and the price, are unaffected. Where the standard binds, its constraint $\ell \leq 0$ involves the default intensity through $\ell = S + a(d)B$, so the separation of Proposition 1 fails. The sovereign then applies the rule (8) at its own shadow price of debt, $\hat{q} = -V_B/u'(c)$, instead of the market price (Proposition A.6). The shadow price is below the market price, because the sovereign would like to issue and cannot. So it values its arrears less and defaults more. This is the default margin of Section 3.1 at the shadow price.

3.3 The Deterministic Model

The deterministic model gives a sovereign's debt capacity, and the motion of its debt on either side of it, in closed form. For a risk-neutral sovereign it also answers whether lenders' pessimism alone can carry debt past that capacity. With z fixed, normalized to 0, the equilibrium is a pair of ordinary differential equations. Writing S^*, c^*, d^* for the policies, (6) and (10) read

$$V'(B) = \frac{\rho V(B) - u(c^*)}{S^*}, \qquad q'(B) = \frac{\xi(d^*)q(B) - (1-d^*)(\lambda+\delta)}{S^*}, \tag{16}$$

with $d^* = d^*(B, q(B))$ from Proposition 2, $c^* = (u')^{-1}(-V'/q)$, and $S^* = (c^* - \mathcal{R}^*)/q$. The system is singular where the drift vanishes, and the stationary points of debt organize the solution. We call a zero of the drift a *steady state*. Theorem 1 pins down one of them within the class of no-default-basin equilibria, the no-default steady state B^*. A zero inside the partial-default region would be a self-fulfilling partial-default steady state, discussed at the end of this subsection.

Definition 2. An equilibrium of the deterministic model is of *no-default-basin type* with steady state $B^* \in (0, \bar{B})$ if $d \equiv 0$ on $[0, B^*]$, $S > 0$ on $[0, B^*)$, $S(B^*) = 0$, and $S < 0$ on $(B^*, \bar{B}]$. It satisfies the *finite-reach condition* if from $B^* + x$ the state reaches B^* in a time $\tau(x) \to 0$ as $x \downarrow 0$.

Theorem 1 (the deterministic steady state in closed form)**.** *In the deterministic model, let (V, q) be a no-default-basin equilibrium satisfying the finite-reach condition. Then $q \equiv q^{\mathrm{rf}}$ on $[0, B^*]$, $V(B^*) = u(1 - rB^*)/\rho$, and*

$$B^* = B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q^{\mathrm{rf}}),$$

the largest debt the sovereign is willing to service in full at the risk-free price, given explicitly by Proposition 2(e) with $q = q^{\mathrm{rf}}$.

The steady state is where the impatient sovereign, borrowing at the risk-free price, runs into its own default threshold. We call it the sovereign's *debt capacity*. It is a closed form in the primitives, because the default decision that defines it is a static comparison of the gain from the first default with the fixed cost. Capacity is increasing in the default costs γ_0 and $1 - F$, in income, and in the recovery κ, since a higher recovery makes withholding more expensive. It is decreasing in $\delta + \lambda$, and independent of ρ (as long as $\rho > r$), of the curvature of u, of the drift

cap, and of the borrowing limit. Table 4 confirms the comparative statics on computed solutions. Steady-state consumption is $1 - rB^*$ and the first partial default beyond B^* has intensity d_{first}. On the basin $[0, B^*)$ the sovereign faces the constant risk-free price and borrows up to the steady state, which it reaches in finite time. The approach is governed by a square-root law.

Lemma 2 (the square-root law)**.** *In the deterministic model, let (V, q) be a no-default-basin equilibrium with V twice continuously differentiable on $(0, B^*)$ and S continuous at B^*, and write $\psi := u'/|u''|$ for the absolute risk tolerance and $\bar{c} = 1 - rB^*$. Then as $x \downarrow 0$*

$$S(B^* - x) = \left(2(\rho - r)\,\psi(\bar{c})\right)^{1/2} x^{1/2}\,(1 + o(1)),$$

and the state reaches B^* from the left in finite time.

Proof. On the basin $q \equiv q^{\text{rf}}$ and $d \equiv 0$, so $c = 1 - rB + S$ and the HJB equation reads $\rho V = u(c) + SV'$ with $V' = -u'(c)$. Differentiating in B and substituting the first-order condition gives $SS' = rS - (\rho - r)\,\psi(c)$. As $B \uparrow B^*$ the drift vanishes and $c \to \bar{c}$, so $(S^2)' \to -2(\rho - r)\psi(\bar{c})$, which integrates to the stated law. The time to reach B^* from $B^* - x$ is $\int_0^x dy/S(B^* - y) \propto x^{1/2}$, which is finite. □

The square-root law is the impatient sovereign's approach to a limit it cannot cross at the risk-free price.

Beyond B^* the sovereign is in partial default, the price is below q^{rf}, and the drift is negative, so the state returns to B^* from above.

Theorem 2 (the cube-root law at the steady state)**.** *In the deterministic model, let (V, q) be a no-default-basin equilibrium with the finite-reach condition and $d_{\text{first}} < 1$, and suppose that on a right neighborhood of B^* the drift is interior and V is C^1. Let u be real-analytic near $\bar{c}$, as CRRA utility is (for the second-order terms and the last statement). Write $x = B - B^*$, $\bar{c} = 1 - rB^*$, and*

$$\Pi_0 := (1 - \kappa)(\delta + \lambda)\,d_{\text{first}}, \qquad \beta := \left(3\,a(d_{\text{first}})\,B^*\,\Pi_0\,\frac{u'(\bar{c})}{|u''(\bar{c})|}\right)^{1/3}, \qquad \alpha := \frac{3\Pi_0}{2\beta}.$$

Then as $x \downarrow 0$,

$$S(B^* + x) = -\beta\,x^{1/3}\,(1 + o(1)), \qquad c(B^* + x) = \bar{c} - \beta\,x^{1/3}\,(1 + o(1)),$$
$$q^{\text{rf}} - q(B^* + x) = \alpha\,x^{2/3}\,(1 + o(1)),$$

and $V'(B^{*+}) = -u'(\bar{c}) = V'(B^{*-})$. More precisely, with $\psi(c) := u'(c)/|u''(c)|$,

$$S(B^* + x) = -\beta\,x^{1/3} - \Sigma_1\,x^{2/3} + O(x), \qquad q^{\text{rf}} - q(B^* + x) = \alpha\,x^{2/3} + Q_1\,x + O(x^{4/3}),$$
$$\Sigma_1 = -\frac{1}{4}\left[\beta^2\frac{u'''(\bar{c})}{|u''(\bar{c})|} + \frac{3\psi(\bar{c})\,(\rho - r + \Pi_0)}{\beta}\right], \qquad Q_1 = -\frac{\Pi_0\,\Sigma_1}{\beta^2},$$

where $u'''(\bar{c})/|u''(\bar{c})| = (\nu+1)/\bar{c}$ for CRRA utility with relative risk aversion ν. Both terms in the bracket are positive when u is prudent and $\rho > r$, so $\Sigma_1 < 0$. Thus V is C^1 but not C^2 at the steady state, the drift leaves zero with a vertical tangent, and the price has a vertical tangent from the right. Moreover the right branch exists on a right neighborhood of B^*, is unique among branches that stay bounded in the scaled variables $(q^{\mathrm{rf}} - q)/x^{2/3}$ and $-qS/x^{1/3}$ as $x \downarrow 0$ (hence among those with these asymptotics), and is an analytic function of $(B - B^*)^{1/3}$ (Appendix A).

The cube-root law describes gradual deleveraging. A sovereign over its capacity works its debt down at a speed that falls as it nears capacity, and it arrives in finite time, to leading order $(3/(2\beta))\, x^{2/3}$. In the illustration below this is about 0.4 years from an excess of one percent of output and 1.9 years from ten percent. Even a small excess, however, lowers the price visibly at once. With a binary default decision the sovereign would jump into default instead. On the right branch the HJB equation reads $\rho V = u(c) + w\, u'(c)$, with $w = -qS \geq 0$ the resources devoted to repayment. Letting $B \downarrow B^*$ forces $c \to \bar{c}$ and hence $S \to 0$, and differentiating gives $w' \approx M/w^2$ with $M := a(d_{\mathrm{first}})B^*\Pi_0\, \psi(\bar{c})$, whence $w^3 \approx 3Mx$. The price gap then integrates $q' \approx -\Pi_0/w$ to the two-thirds power. The constant Π_0 is the flow of debt service lost at the first default, net of the arrears it creates. The price has a vertical tangent to the right of the steady state because a small excursion into default costs lenders this flow at a rate that does not vanish, over a time that is only $O(x^{2/3})$.

The equilibrium with these properties exists. Its left branch is the unique solution of the basin equation of Lemma 2 that reaches B^*, and its right branch is the solution of (16) that leaves B^* along the cube-root law. Proposition A.9 in Appendix A shows that together they form a no-default-basin equilibrium, the only one with these asymptotics, whenever the right branch stays regular up to full default. The condition is on an explicit initial-value problem, not on an equilibrium, so it can be checked at any parameters. Its main requirement is that the drift of the right branch have no second zero before full default. The computed solution in the illustration satisfies it. A second zero would be a self-fulfilling partial-default steady state.

Self-fulfilling partial default. In the equilibrium of Theorem 1, lenders expect full repayment and the price is q^{rf}. Suppose instead that lenders expect the sovereign to settle at a debt B°, typically above its capacity, and to withhold a constant share d° of its debt service there forever. They then pay at B° the price of a bond that defaults at rate d° forever,

$$q_r(d) := \frac{(1-d)(\lambda+\delta)}{\xi(d)},$$

and less than q^{rf} at every lower debt, since every path leads to B°. Two consequences validate the expectation. First, default starts earlier. At a lower price the arrears created by withholding a unit of debt service are worth less, so withholding costs the sovereign less (Lemma 1). The threshold $B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q)$ falls with the price (Proposition 2), and the sovereign defaults at debt levels at which it would repay in full at the risk-free price. Second, the sovereign can borrow past its

old limit. Because the default is priced, the sovereign pays only the risk-free rate on the funds it raises: at the steady state its net payments to lenders, debt service less issuance, are $rq^\circ B^\circ$ per unit of time. Since it discounts at $\rho > r$, it wants to borrow. It stops at B° only because there each further unit of debt lowers the price at which it must roll over the rest, and the impatience wedge balances this dilution exactly (Lemma A.1). At B° the sovereign withholds the share that lenders expected. There is no run and no loss of market access. With curvature the sovereign drifts into a permanent partial default over years, paying an output cost that exists only because lenders expected the default.

Lemma A.1 in Appendix A gives the local conditions at such a point: the price is $q_r(d^\circ)$, its slope to the right is pinned by the impatience wedge, $-q'(B^{\circ+})/q^\circ = (\rho - r)/(a(d^\circ)B^\circ)$, and the point attracts only if additional debt dilutes the price strongly enough through additional default. These conditions admit a continuum of candidates, one for every intensity $d^\circ \geq d_{\text{first}}$. Whether a candidate is an equilibrium is a two-point problem: the sovereign must be willing to borrow into partial default, at prices below q^{rf}, all the way from zero debt. Two cases can be settled analytically, with the underwriting standard and with a risk-neutral sovereign. Both are governed by the stationary spread at the first default intensity, the spread lenders charge a sovereign that withholds forever the smallest share it ever withholds,

$$s_{\text{first}} := (\lambda + \delta)\left(\frac{1}{q_r(d_{\text{first}})} - 1\right) = \frac{(1-\kappa)(\lambda+\delta)\, d_{\text{first}}}{1 - d_{\text{first}}}.$$

Proposition 3 (the standard and self-fulfilling partial default)**.** *In the deterministic model with the underwriting standard, every partial-default steady state has a price at or above the floor, $q_r(d^\circ) \geq \underline{q}$. Since q_r is decreasing and $d^\circ \geq d_{\text{first}}$, a self-fulfilling partial-default steady state can exist only if $q_r(d_{\text{first}}) \geq \underline{q}$, that is, only if the stationary spread at the first default does not exceed the spread at the floor,*

$$s_{\text{first}} \leq (\lambda + \delta)\left(\frac{1}{\underline{q}} - 1\right).$$

The condition involves neither the discount rate nor the utility function.

Standing still requires issuance. At a steady state the sovereign must replace the debt that matures and is not replaced by arrears, $\ell = a(d^\circ)B^\circ > 0$, and the standard forbids issuance below the floor.

A risk-neutral sovereign. With linear utility the sovereign does not smooth consumption, and the existence question has a nearly complete answer. We let issuance be unrestricted in speed, so that the sovereign can issue a block of debt at once, at the price of the state it moves to. DeMarzo, He, and Tourre (2023) study a closely related problem in continuous time: an impatient, risk-neutral sovereign that cannot commit to a debt path and borrows from competitive lenders.

Define for $d \in [d_{\text{first}}, 1)$ the stationary spread $s(d) := (1-\kappa)(\lambda+\delta)d/(1-d)$ and

$$\Theta(d) := s(d)\,\frac{1+(\gamma_1-1)(d_{\text{first}}/d)^{\gamma_1}}{\gamma_1},$$

the output cost of withholding the share d forever, per unit of the funds the sovereign raises by issuing at once the debt of the steady state with that intensity (Proposition A.10).

Proposition 4 (self-fulfilling partial default with a risk-neutral sovereign)**.** *Let $u(c) = c$ and $\rho > r$ in the deterministic model, with issuance unrestricted in speed.*

(a) In any equilibrium in which debt goes from zero to a partial-default steady state, $\rho - r \geq \Theta^* := \min_{d \geq d_{\text{first}}} \Theta(d)$.

(b) $\Theta(d_{\text{first}}) = s_{\text{first}}$, and if $\gamma_1 \leq 2$, Θ is increasing and $\Theta^* = s_{\text{first}}$.

(c) If $(\gamma_1 - 1)\xi(d_{\text{first}}) < \delta$ and $q_r(d_{\text{first}}) > \underline{q}$, there is a bound $\bar{\Omega} > s_{\text{first}}$, in closed form in Proposition A.10, such that for every wedge $\rho - r$ in $(s_{\text{first}}, \bar{\Omega})$ there are self-fulfilling partial-default equilibria, in which the sovereign issues the debt of a steady state at once from zero debt and withholds a constant share there forever, provided the price schedule continues regularly above the steady state.

The condition $\rho - r \geq \Theta(d)$ is a comparison that a sovereign at zero debt can make directly. Issuing at once the debt of the steady state with intensity d raises its market value. From then on the sovereign pays lenders the risk-free rate on the funds raised, because the default is priced, and it loses $1 - \phi(d, 0)$ of output to the default. Relative to staying debt-free forever, front-loading gains the impatience wedge times the funds raised, per unit of time. The block reaches the pessimistic steady state when this gain covers the output cost. By part (a), no route from zero debt reaches any partial-default steady state when the wedge is below the cheapest block's threshold Θ^*. For a given steady state the block test is sufficient but not necessary, since a smaller block followed by gradual borrowing into default can also reach it. Part (b) identifies the threshold with the spread implied by the first default. At the first default the output cost equals the payments saved net of the arrears created, and at the stationary price this equals the spread times the value of the debt. With a more convex variable cost, deeper defaults cost less relative to their spread, and the threshold can lie below s_{first}. Every intensity that passes the test gives an equilibrium. So when one self-fulfilling steady state exists a continuum does, and lenders' expectations alone select among them. The bound $\bar{\Omega}$ in part (c) is an attraction condition: at a larger wedge the steady state no longer attracts debt from above. In the numerical example of Figure 3, where $\gamma_1 = 1.5$ and $(\gamma_1 - 1)\xi(d_{\text{first}}) = 0.075 < \delta = 0.12$, the threshold is $s_{\text{first}} = 47$ basis points and $\bar{\Omega} = 80$ basis points.

Curvature. With CRRA utility the sovereign cannot jump, and it borrows into default gradually. Above a candidate steady state the price follows the solutions of Proposition A.10(a). From below, the state arrives along a square-root law with a nearly flat price, and away from the candidates

curvature slows the borrowing. We find the candidates reached from zero debt by integrating (16) forward from zero debt, over a grid of starting prices and consumption levels. Figure 3 shows a numerical example with $\nu = 2$ and a wedge of 210 basis points, computed by the branching march of Appendix B.1. Next to the no-default steady state at $B = 0.70$ there is a self-fulfilling partial-default steady state at $B = 1.00$, at which the sovereign withholds 28 percent of its debt service at a price of 0.90, a spread of 183 basis points. Facing those prices, the sovereign borrows from zero debt all the way into partial default. Default starts at $B = 0.62$, lower than under the optimistic price, because the threshold rises with the price. This steady state is one of a continuum: at this wedge the steady states reached from zero debt fill the interval from 0.93 to 1.02. The left panel of Figure 4 shows the smallest wedge at which any is reached, as a function of the curvature. It is about 139 basis points for $\nu = 2$, against 47 for a risk-neutral sovereign. A sovereign that values smooth consumption gains less from front-loading, so it needs more impatience to borrow into default.

In every case we computed, a self-fulfilling partial-default steady state is reached from zero debt with curvature only above a threshold that exceeds the risk-neutral threshold Θ^* and rises with the curvature of utility. The threshold approaches Θ^* as the curvature vanishes, but slowly, so even a little curvature raises it markedly.

Uncertainty. Shocks also work against self-fulfilling partial default. We study them with a risk-neutral sovereign and extend the construction of Proposition A.10 to the diffusion model (Appendix A.5). Lenders expect the sovereign to settle at a debt B° that does not depend on the endowment, and to stay there. The default intensity and the price at B° then vary with the endowment. A sovereign at zero debt issues the debt B° in a block when that beats staying debt-free, and above B° it is indifferent, as in Proposition A.10(a). The right panel of Figure 4 shows where such equilibria exist, at the parameters of Figure 3. Volatility narrows the range of supporting wedges from both sides. From below, the block must beat staying debt-free in every endowment state, and in bad states the pessimistic steady state carries a deeper and costlier default. From above, the steady state must attract debt in every state, and the dilution that holds the sovereign there is weaker in some states. At a standard deviation of the log endowment of about 7 percent the two boundaries meet, and no equilibrium of this kind remains. Section 4.3 returns to the question at the calibrated parameters.

Self-fulfilling partial default is the continuous-time form of the slow-moving debt crises of Lorenzoni and Werning (2019). In their model a pessimistic price raises the cost of rolling over the debt, and the sovereign borrows into a crisis that validates the price. The crisis unfolds slowly because debt is a stock that moves at the rate of the deficit. The idea that an expected repudiation raises the interest rate, and that the higher rate justifies the repudiation, goes back to Calvo (1988). In our model the same logic runs through arrears. A pessimistic price raises the default intensity the sovereign chooses, the higher intensity justifies the price, and debt moves at the rate of the deficit and of the arrears. Unlike the rollover crises of Cole and Kehoe (2000),

self-fulfilling partial default involves no run. It is closer to the crises of Aguiar et al. (2022), in which the government keeps issuing at depressed prices. The difference from Lorenzoni and Werning (2019) is where the sovereign's willingness to participate enters. In their setting the sovereign must roll over. In ours it can stay out of the default region, and a candidate survives only if borrowing into default at the pessimistic price beats staying out (Proposition 4).

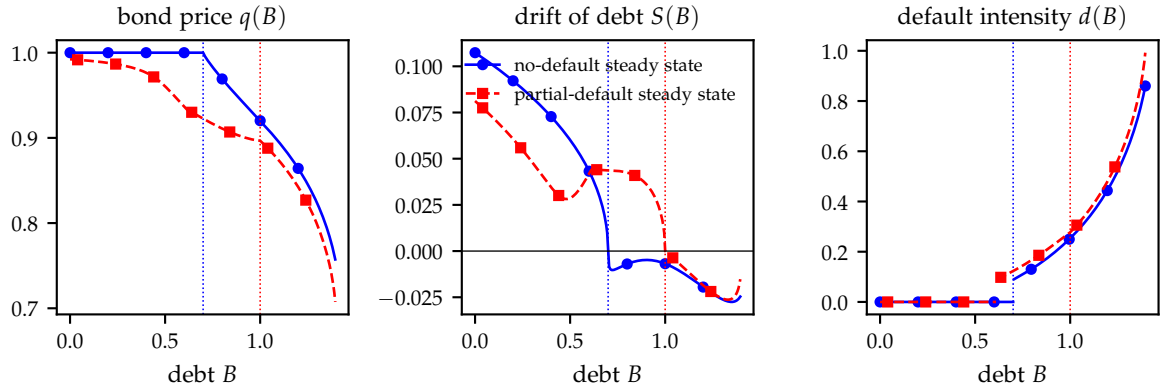


Figure 3: A numerical example of self-fulfilling partial default: two equilibria of the deterministic model at the same parameters ($\gamma_0 = 0.075$, $\gamma_1 = 1.5$, fixed-cost factor $F(0) = 0.999$, $\rho = 0.06$, $\delta = 0.12$, $\kappa = 0.7$, $r = \lambda = 0.039$, $\nu = 2$, standard at 0.7; first default $d_{\text{first}} = 0.09$, impatience wedge 210 basis points): the no-default steady state at $B = 0.70$ and a self-fulfilling partial-default steady state at $B = 1.00$, where the sovereign withholds 28 percent of its debt service at a price of 0.90. The second is one of a continuum: at this wedge the partial-default steady states reached from zero debt fill the interval from 0.93 to 1.02. Dotted lines: the two steady states. Computed by the branching march of Appendix B.1.

Numerical illustration. Figure 5 shows the deterministic equilibrium in the illustration, with the endowment fixed at its mean and the underwriting standard at $\underline{q} = 0.6$. It is computed by the implicit upwind time stepping of Appendix B on a grid with 500 nodes per unit of debt on $[0, 1.5]$, to residuals of 10^{-7} and 5×10^{-9}. The drift vanishes at the node 0.482, where the stationary distribution has its atom, against $B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}}) = 0.485$ from (15). The first default node, 0.484, carries $d = 0.517$ against $d_{\text{first}} = 0.52$ from (14). The underwriting standard binds from $B = 0.888$, where the price falls through 0.6 (dashed vertical line). Beyond that point issuance is zero and the drift is $-a(d)B$. From $B = 1.37$ default is complete, and the price follows the power law of Proposition A.9. Figure 6 shows the value and consumption. The value is C^1 through the steady state, as Theorem 2 says. Consumption falls steeply at the first default, with the vertical tangent of the cube-root law, but it is continuous there. At the threshold the resource function takes the same value at $d = 0$ and at d_{first}, and the drift vanishes on both sides. What the grid shows as a drop is, to leading order, $\beta h^{1/3}$ for a grid step h. Figure 7 checks Theorem 2. On log-log axes it compares the computed drift and price gap to the right of the steady state, and the drift to its left, with the two-term expansions of the theorem and with the square-root law. The constants $\beta = 0.172$, $\alpha = 0.54$, $\Sigma_1 = -0.203$, and $Q_1 = 0.425$ are computed from the primitives.

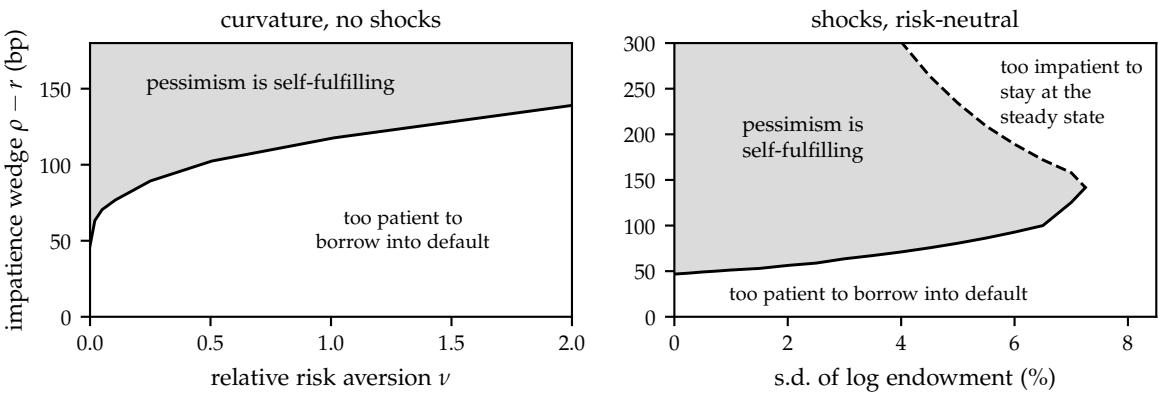


Figure 4: Where pessimism is self-fulfilling. Shaded: impatience wedges $\rho - r$ at which a self-fulfilling partial-default equilibrium exists, at the parameters of Figure 3. Both solid lines start at the risk-neutral threshold of the deterministic model, $s_{\text{first}} = 47$ basis points (Proposition 4). The two panels have different vertical scales. Left: the deterministic model with CRRA utility. The line is the smallest wedge at which a partial-default steady state is reached from zero debt, against the relative risk aversion ν. The upper boundary is not computed. Right: the risk-neutral diffusion model with a steady debt that does not depend on the endowment (Appendix A.5), against the standard deviation of the log endowment, with mean reversion $\mu = 0.225$. Below the solid line the sovereign is too patient to borrow into default. Above the dashed line the steady state no longer attracts debt.

The leading terms alone describe the solution only well inside the first grid step. The ratio Σ_1/β is -1.2, so the second term of the drift is half the first already at $x = 0.1$. The second term is large mostly through Π_0, since the first default is half of the debt service here. With two terms the drift is matched to within 7 percent for x between 0.01 and 0.05. The price gap is matched to within 3 percent for x between 0.02 and 0.05 and 7 percent up to 0.2. Within five grid steps of the steady state the comparison is limited by the grid's placement of the steady state, which the law itself says is off by $O(h)$.

3.4 The Chain Model

Uncertainty adds a precautionary motive and a kink in the price schedule, which together decide how defaults begin. Let the log endowment take finitely many values z_j and switch from j to k at rate η_{jk}. The HJB and pricing equations are

$$\rho V_j(B) = \max_{c,\,d} \left\{ u(c) + S\,V_j'(B) + \sum_{k \neq j} \eta_{jk} \big[V_k(B) - V_j(B) \big] \right\},$$

$$\xi(d_j)\, q_j(B) = (1 - d_j)(\lambda + \delta) + \tilde{S}_j\, q_j'(B) + \sum_{k \neq j} \eta_{jk} \big[q_k(B) - q_j(B) \big].$$

Proposition 1 and the thresholds of Proposition 2 hold state by state with $q = q_j(B)$. The precautionary motive can hold a steady state at the risk-free price short of capacity.

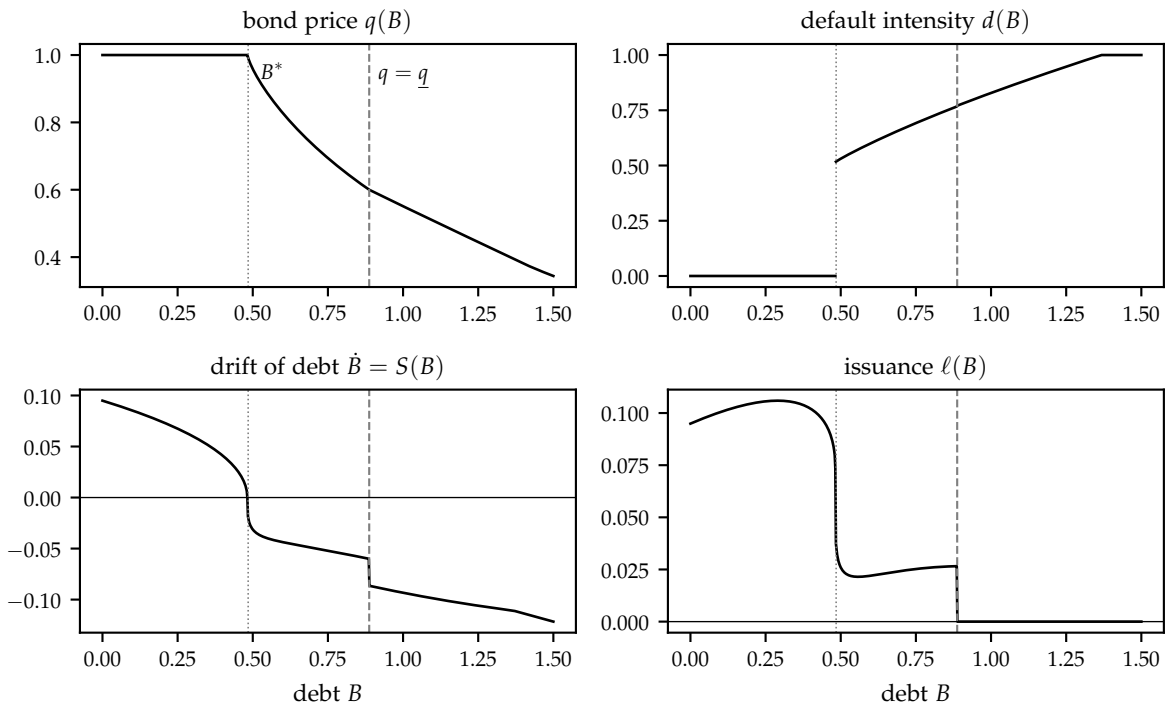


Figure 5: The deterministic model: bond price, default intensity, drift of debt, and issuance as functions of debt. Parameters of Table 1 with the endowment at its mean. Dotted vertical line: the steady state $B^* = B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q^{\mathrm{rf}})$. Dashed vertical line: the debt at which the price falls through the floor $\underline{q}$.

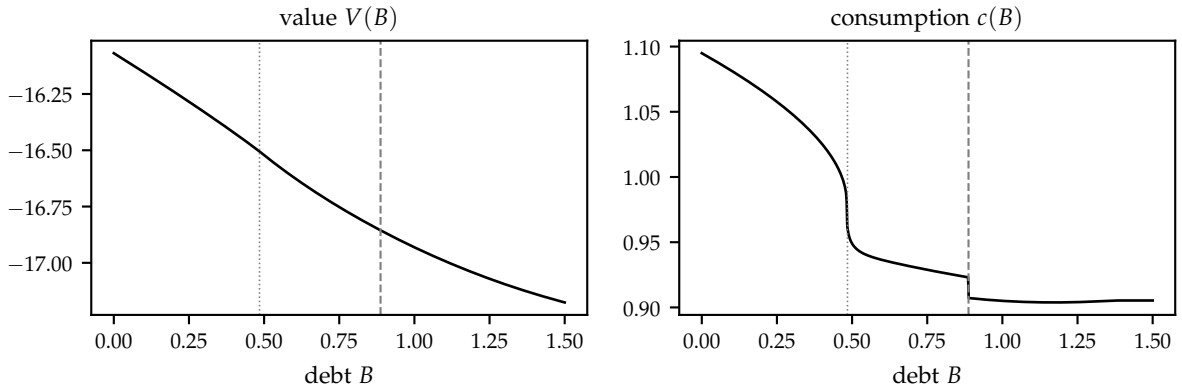


Figure 6: The deterministic model: value and consumption as functions of debt. The value is C^1 at the steady state (Theorem 2). Consumption falls steeply but continuously at the first default, with the vertical tangent of the cube-root law, and is nearly flat in the default region, with a small step where the underwriting standard starts to bind (dashed vertical line).

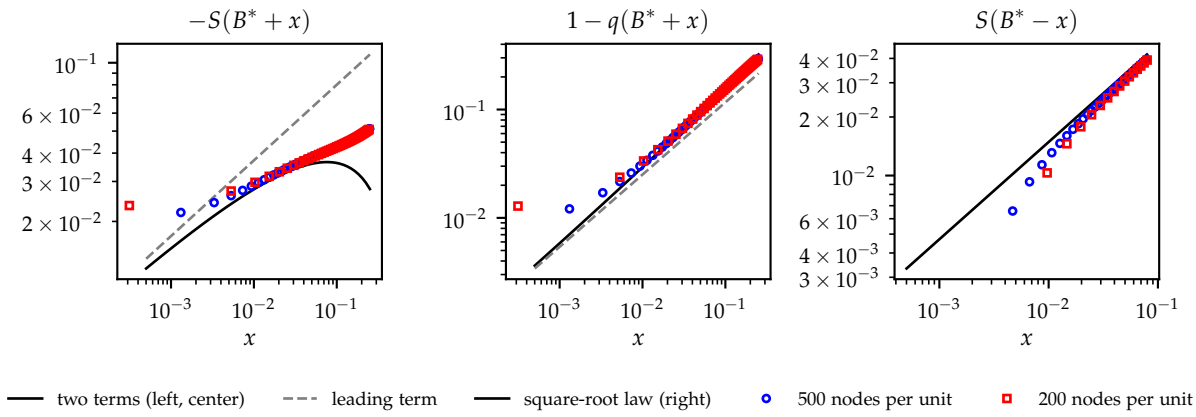


Figure 7: The cube-root law at the steady state. Markers: the computed drift and price gap at a distance x above the steady state (left and center) and the drift at a distance x below it (right), on two grids. Lines: the two-term expansions of Theorem 2 (solid) and their leading terms (dashed), with constants computed from the primitives. In the right panel, the line is the square-root law.

Proposition 5 (steady states at the risk-free price in the chain model)**.** *In the chain model, suppose* $[0, \underline{B}]$ *is invariant under the equilibrium dynamics in every state and no state defaults on it. Then* $q_j \equiv q^{\mathrm{rf}}$ *on* $[0, \underline{B}]$ *for every* j *and* $\underline{B} \leq \min_j B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z_j, q^{\mathrm{rf}})$*. If state* j *has a steady state at an interior point* B° *of* $[0, \underline{B}]$*, at which* V_j *is twice differentiable, every* V_k *is differentiable, and the drift cap and the consumption floor are slack, then*

$$(\rho - r)\, u'(c_j) = \sum_{k \neq j} \eta_{jk} \left(u'(c_k) - u'(c_j) \right) \qquad \text{at } B^\circ. \tag{17}$$

In particular, a state whose consumption at B° *is the lowest across states has no steady state in the interior of* $[0, \underline{B}]$*.*

Condition (17) is the Euler equation at a stationary point: the impatience gain from borrowing a little balances the precautionary loss from arriving in a worse state with more debt. In the state with the lowest consumption the precautionary term is nonpositive and nothing offsets the impatience term, so the sovereign cannot rest inside the default-free set and borrows to its edge. In a better state the two terms compete, and a second force works through prices. Beyond the threshold of a state that can be reached in one switch, a switch triggers an immediate first default. So the price schedule of the better state has a kink there, and the marginal revenue of issuance drops. Numerically, in two-state chains with the default costs of the illustration, the high state stays at or below the low state's threshold, and default does not occur in the ergodic set. This holds in eight of the nine combinations of shock size and switching rate we examined.[4] The high state is at the threshold, pinned by the kink, in six, where both states share a point mass at that debt level. It is below the threshold, held by precaution as in Proposition 5, in two. In the three-state illustration below, where a rare jump to the lowest state leads to default, no default-free invariant set contains the steady states, and all of them sit at default thresholds.

4. Nine combinations of shocks of 4, 5, 8, and 11 percent and switching rates of 0.03, 0.05, 0.07, and 0.10. In six of them the pricing residual stalled between 2×10^{-4} and 2×10^{-2}.

Numerical illustration. Figure 8 shows the equilibrium with three states, $z \in \{-0.08, 0, +0.08\}$. The low state rises to the middle one at the rate $\eta = 0.100$, and the middle and high states switch with each other at the same rate. Both upper states jump down to the low state only at the rare rate $\epsilon = 0.03$, once every three decades. Apart from these jumps the two upper states form a symmetric two-state chain, and η is half the mean-reversion rate $\mu = -\ln \rho_z$ of the diffusion model (Section 4.1), the rate at which such a chain matches the diffusion's autocorrelation. The rare jump is the device that lets a chain catch the sovereign on the wrong side of a threshold. The solution is computed on a grid with 201 nodes on $[0, 1]$ with the standard at $\underline{q} = 0.6$, by the time stepping of Appendix B.2, to residuals of 10^{-7} and 3×10^{-9}. The default thresholds are $B = 0.350$, 0.475, and 0.615 in the low, middle, and high state, and the default intensity jumps to 0.46 at the first. The middle state borrows up to the node just below its own threshold, $B = 0.470$, and stops there. The rare jump is too unlikely to hold it back, so it is pinned by its own threshold, as in the deterministic model. The high state stops earlier, at the node just below the low state's threshold, $B = 0.345$, where the kink in its price schedule pins it. At that node the impatience term of (17) exceeds the precautionary term, 0.020 against 0.018, so at a flat price the high state would borrow further. The price there is within one percent of q^{rf}. From wherever it starts, the low state repays down to the node just below its own threshold, the same node. The ergodic distribution, shown by state in the last panel, has atoms at the two thresholds. It has mass 0.28 in the middle state at its own threshold, and mass 0.16 in the low state and 0.09 in the high state at the low state's threshold. It also has a continuous part in every state between the two thresholds, traced by the paths that follow a switch. Default happens along these paths. A jump from the middle state's atom lands the sovereign in partial default at $B = 0.470$, above the low state's threshold, and it withholds a share of its debt service while it repays. Default occurs on 0.07 of the ergodic mass, all of it in the low state, and mean debt is 0.41. Unlike in the calibrated diffusion model (Section 4.3), debt does not rise during these episodes: in the low state the sovereign repays from the moment it defaults.

Existence and the price cliffs. Given policies, the prices are the Feynman–Kac values (9) and are continuous except possibly at points where the drift vanishes or changes sign that are not reached in finite time from both sides (Proposition A.2). In our computations without the underwriting standard the chain model has such a point in the lowest state at the full-default threshold, and the price jumps there. With the standard, every stationary point of the computed solution is reached from both sides and the prices are continuous. A general existence theorem for the coupled equilibrium is not available: the best-response map from prices to prices is discontinuous (thresholds move with q) and not monotone (a higher price lowers default today but raises borrowing), so neither Schauder's nor Tarski's theorem applies directly. We show in Appendix A (Proposition A.11) that the best response does preserve the class of prices nonincreasing in debt, when the induced debt flow is order preserving and the standard is slack.

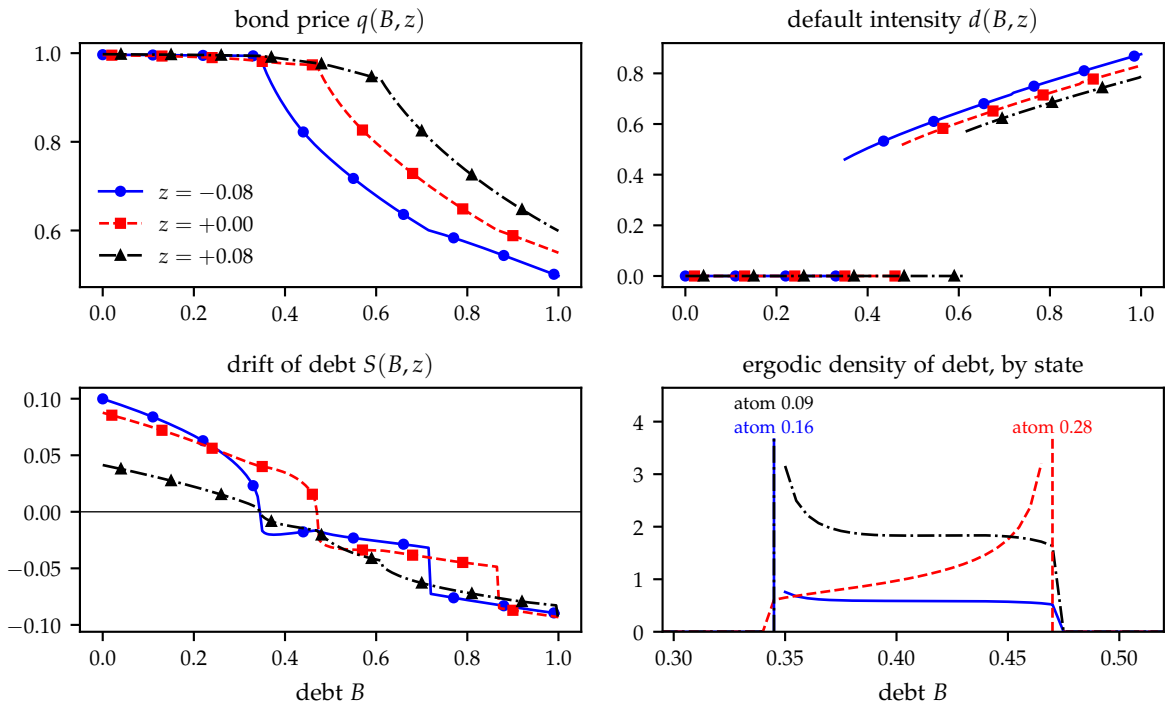


Figure 8: The chain model with three states: bond price, default intensity, and drift of debt by endowment state, and the ergodic density of debt by state (atoms are drawn as spikes). Parameters of Table 1, with $z \in \{-0.08, 0, 0.08\}$. The low state rises to the middle one, and the two upper states switch with each other, at the rate 0.100. Both upper states jump to the low state at the rate 0.03.

4 Quantitative Analysis

This section calibrates the diffusion model to the targets of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) and shows the results of Section 3 at work in the calibrated model. The regions of default and the debt capacity appear in the policies, the debt targets in the shape of the ergodic set, and the fixed cost in the response to a shock.

4.1 The Diffusion Model

The log endowment follows an Ornstein–Uhlenbeck process, $dz_t = -\mu z_t\,dt + \sigma\,dW_t$, reflected at $\pm\bar{z}$. Its generator is $\mathcal{L}_z = -\mu z\,\partial_z + \frac{1}{2}\sigma^2\partial_{zz}$, so the HJB and pricing equations are

$$\begin{aligned} \rho V &= \max_{c,\,d} \left\{ u(c) + S\,V_B - \mu z\,V_z + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2 V_{zz} \right\}, \\ \xi(d)\,q &= (1-d)(\lambda+\delta) + \tilde{S}\,q_B - \mu z\,q_z + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2 q_{zz}, \end{aligned} \tag{18}$$

with Neumann conditions $V_z = q_z = 0$ at $\pm\bar{z}$, and the stationary density solves

$$0 = -\partial_B\left[\tilde{S}\,g\right] + \partial_z[\mu z\,g] + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma^2\,\partial_{zz} g,$$

with zero-flux conditions $\mu z g + \frac{1}{2}\sigma^2 g_z = 0$ at $z = \pm\bar{z}$ and $\tilde{S}g = 0$ at $B = \bar{B}$, and an atom at $B = 0$ that collects the inflow where $\tilde{S}(0^+, z) < 0$. The process is the continuous-time counterpart of the annual AR(1) of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023): an AR(1) with persistence ρ_z and innovation standard deviation σ_ϵ observed at annual frequency corresponds to $\mu = -\ln\rho_z$ and a stationary standard deviation $\sigma_\epsilon/\sqrt{1-\rho_z^2} = \sigma/\sqrt{2\mu}$. Given a continuous price, (18) is a degenerate elliptic equation with a state constraint in B. The value function is its unique constrained viscosity solution and is Lipschitz in B (Soner 1986; Capuzzo-Dolcetta and Lions 1990; Fleming and Soner 2006), and the upwind scheme of Appendix B.3 converges to it (Barles and Souganidis 1991). The coupled equilibrium is computed as the fixed point of the two equations.

4.2 Calibration and Computation

Strategy. Utility is CRRA, $u(c) = c^{1-\nu}/(1-\nu)$, and the default cost is (3), the level form of the fixed cost used by Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023). We follow their calibration as closely as the continuous-time formulation allows. Risk aversion $\nu = 2$ and the risk-free rate $r = \ln 1.04$ are fixed. Our free parameters are the nine they estimate: the default cost parameters $\gamma_0, \gamma_1, \gamma_2, y^*$, the discount rate ρ, the recovery κ, the maturity rate δ, and the endowment parameters ρ_z, σ_ϵ mapped as above. The targets are the eleven moments of their Table 4, with their weights (three on the mean of debt due to output, 1.25 on the standard deviation of the spread, one on the rest). The loss is the weighted sum of squared proportional deviations. The underwriting standard is set at $\underline{q} = 0.6$ (Section 2.4).

Accounting and moments. Debt due is $(\delta + \lambda)B$ per year, debt service is $(1 - d)$ times debt due, defaulted coupons are d times debt due, and the annual partial default is defaulted coupons over debt due within the year, as in their equation (4). The debt level is B, its face value, which equals its risk-free value since $q^{\mathrm{rf}} = 1$. Output and consumption are annual integrals, logged and linearly detrended. A year is in partial default if any coupon was defaulted on during it. At the calibrated point the instantaneous probability of being in default under the stationary distribution is 0.27, against an annual frequency of 0.38, a difference due to time aggregation. Moments that are functions of the state (debt, debt service, and debt due to output, the spread and its correlations) are computed exactly from the stationary distribution of the discretized process, by solving the adjoint system of Appendix B.3. Moments that are path functionals under annual accounting (the partial default frequency, mean and standard deviation, the persistence and volatility of output, and consumption) are computed from sixteen simulated paths of 25,000 years each, as are the untargeted moments conditional on default.

Parameters. Table 1 reports the parameters next to those of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023). The calibration runs twelve Nelder–Mead searches of 300 evaluations each on a coarser endowment grid. It continues the four best for 100 evaluations each on the 75-node grid and reports the best point at which the standard binds on less than one percent of the ergodic mass. Relative to their values, the recovery is lower, and the variable default cost is higher and more convex. The fixed cost rises less steeply with output but starts at a lower output level. The discount rate and the maturity rate are somewhat higher, and the endowment is somewhat less persistent, with larger innovations.

Computation. The equilibrium is computed by the implicit upwind finite difference scheme of Achdou et al. (2022) on a grid of 201 nodes in debt on $[0, 1]$ and 75 nodes in z on ± 2.5 stationary standard deviations. The value and the price are updated jointly at each implicit step, because the alternating iteration between them is unstable. Each parameter evaluation in the calibration solves the model from a warm start in about one minute on a 25-node endowment grid and four minutes on the 75-node grid.[5] At the reported point the HJB residual is at most 9×10^{-7} and the pricing residual at most 10^{-3}, attained next to the zero-drift locus, and 2×10^{-5} elsewhere.[6] No taste shocks or other smoothing of the decision problem are needed, unlike in discrete-time models with long-term debt (Chatterjee and Eyigungor 2012; Mihalache 2025; Section 1). The default intensity is a continuous control, and the monotone three-candidate scheme handles the only non-concavity, the fixed cost's jump at $d = 0$, directly. Appendix B describes the scheme,

5. Every result reported in the paper is computed at the calibrated parameters on the 75-node grid.

6. These maxima exclude the nodes on the floor locus, where the price is within 0.02 of $\underline{q}$ or crosses it between neighboring debt levels. These nodes hold 3.8 percent of the ergodic mass, of which the standard binds on just under one percent. There the standard switches issuance on and off, which makes the discrete policy discontinuous in the price on the locus $q = \underline{q}$, a locus that no grid node hits exactly. The drift sign alternates between iterations, and the residuals stall at 3×10^{-3} for the HJB equation and 2×10^{-2} for the pricing equation. Phasing in issuance continuously over a narrow band of prices around $\underline{q}$ could reduce these errors.

Table 1: Calibration

		AMR (2023)	This paper
Fixed			
ν	risk aversion	2	2
r	risk-free rate ($\ln 1.04$)	0.039	0.039
λ	coupon, $= r$	0.039	0.039
$\underline{q}$	underwriting standard	–	0.60
Calibrated			
γ_0	variable default cost, level	0.0476	0.0759
γ_1	variable default cost, curvature	2.00	3.07
γ_2	fixed default cost, slope	0.120	0.082
y^*	fixed default cost, threshold (level)	0.938	0.751
ρ	discount rate (factor $e^{-\rho}$)	0.047	0.062
κ	recovery of defaulted coupons	0.70	0.373
δ	maturity rate (survival $1-\delta$)	0.12	0.153
ρ_z	annual persistence of the endowment	0.875	0.819
σ_ϵ	annual innovation s.d.	0.052	0.066

Notes: The discrete-time parameters of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) (Table 3) are mapped to continuous time by $\rho = -\ln(\text{discount factor})$, $\delta = 1 - \text{survival rate}$ (which matches their debt service per unit of debt), $\mu = -\ln \rho_z$, $\sigma = \sigma_\epsilon \sqrt{2\mu/(1-\rho_z^2)}$. The free parameters are chosen to minimize the weighted distance to the targets of Table 2, as in their calibration.

the treatment of the non-concave Hamiltonian, the initial guess, the convergence criteria, and the exact marching solution of the deterministic model that we use as a check.

4.3 Quantitative Properties

Fit. Table 2 reports the targeted moments in the data, in the model of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023), and in ours, and the untargeted moments of their Table 4. The loss at the calibrated point is 0.077, against 0.228 for their model under the same weights, most of which comes from their standard deviation of debt to output. The continuous-time model reproduces the frequency of partial default, the mean and dispersion of the default intensity in default, the debt service and debt due ratios, and the output process. It carries somewhat less debt than the data and generates a spread volatility below the target. Among the untargeted moments, the relative volatility of consumption is close to the data. Defaulted coupons in default are lower than in the data, as in their model, and less volatile. The spread is more strongly correlated with output and with debt than in the data, as in their model and more so. With no shocks on the lenders' side, the spread is a function of debt and the endowment alone, so it tracks the state more tightly than a spread that also carries global factors.

Values, policies, and prices. Figures 9 and 10 show the value, the policies, the price, and the ergodic distribution, as functions of debt at four endowment levels and as contour maps over the state space. The value is decreasing in debt and increasing in the endowment. The default

Table 2: Moments in Data and Model

Moment	Weight	Data	AMR (2023)	This paper
Targeted				
Partial default: frequency	1	0.36	0.37	0.38
Partial default: mean $\mid d > 0$	1	0.38	0.39	0.41
Partial default: s.d. $\mid d > 0$	1	0.22	0.19	0.22
Debt to output: mean	1	0.32	0.32	0.27
Debt to output: s.d.	1	0.18	0.25	0.18
Debt service to output: mean	1	0.036	0.035	0.037
Debt service to output: s.d.	1	0.021	0.022	0.020
Debt due to output: mean	3	0.049	0.050	0.052
Spread: s.d.	1.25	0.041	0.037	0.035
Output: persistence	1	0.89	0.88	0.87
Output: s.d.	1	0.10	0.12	0.11
Loss			0.228	0.077
Untargeted				
Defaulted coupons to output: mean $\mid d > 0$		0.052	0.040	0.040
Defaulted coupons to output: s.d. $\mid d > 0$		0.064	0.036	0.027
Spread: mean		0.053	0.016	0.029
Spread: correlation with output		-0.17	-0.38	-0.78
Spread: correlation with debt		0.24	0.56	0.87
Consumption s.d. relative to output s.d.		1.00	0.91	0.93

Notes: Data and the discrete-time model from Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023), Table 4. The loss is the weighted sum of squared proportional deviations from the data.

policy has the structure of Proposition 2. At the lowest endowment shown, $z = -0.29$, just below the fixed-cost threshold $\ln y^* = -0.286$, the sovereign defaults at any positive debt, as Proposition 2(b) says. This no-fixed-cost region contains only the lowest node of the endowment grid, which carries about 0.1 percent of the ergodic mass. There the default intensity rises with debt, along the default margin of Section 3.1, to nearly full default at the top of the grid. At average and high endowments the sovereign does not default until debt reaches the threshold $B_{\text{pd}}(z, q)$, where the default intensity jumps to the first default intensity and rises thereafter. The threshold rises with the endowment, so the no-default region is a wedge in the (B, z) plane. Full default is not reached on the grid at any endowment level. The price is close to q^{rf} in the no-default region at a high endowment and lower at a low endowment, where default is expected after future shocks (between 0.89 and 0.99 at zero debt). The price falls at the default threshold and declines in the default region, through the floor at high debt. Its contours in Figure 10 track the default thresholds. Consumption falls steeply at the default threshold and is nearly flat in debt in the default region, where a higher debt is met with a higher default intensity rather than with lower consumption. The visible steps at a low endowment are where the price crosses the floor and issuance stops.

The drift and the ergodic set. The drift of debt is positive at low debt and negative at high debt in every endowment state below about one standard deviation above the mean, with a single zero-drift locus, the debt target. Down to about one standard deviation below the mean endowment the locus slopes down, so the target is higher in bad times than in good times. In good times the target lies below the no-default threshold, where precaution holds the sovereign short of the fixed cost. In bad times the threshold has fallen below the current debt, and the sovereign in partial default pays the fixed cost regardless. Its target is then set by the dilution of its own price, inside the default region. The episode ends when output recovers and the threshold rises back above the debt, not when the debt is repaid, so the sovereign borrows while it lasts. In worse states the target is the debt at which the price reaches the floor and issuance stops. That debt falls with the endowment, so the locus bends back, from $B = 0.67$ to 0.48 at the lowest endowment node. Above about one standard deviation above the mean endowment the drift is negative at every debt level, and the sovereign repays all the way to zero debt, the atom of the ergodic distribution at $B = 0$. The ergodic set is the region swept by the zero-drift locus as the endowment moves. The density in Figure 10 concentrates along the locus, with most of the mass between zero debt and the deterministic debt capacity $B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}}) = 0.485$ and a tail that extends into the partial-default region at a low endowment. The equilibrium threshold at the average endowment is lower, 0.445, because the price there is 0.85 rather than par. The density thins out above about $B = 0.64$, well before the top of the grid and short of the peak of the locus at 0.67, which the state approaches only slowly. In the worst states the floor locus, where issuance stops, bounds the ergodic set. Spreads are therefore low most of the time and high in the tail, which is where the model's spread volatility comes from.

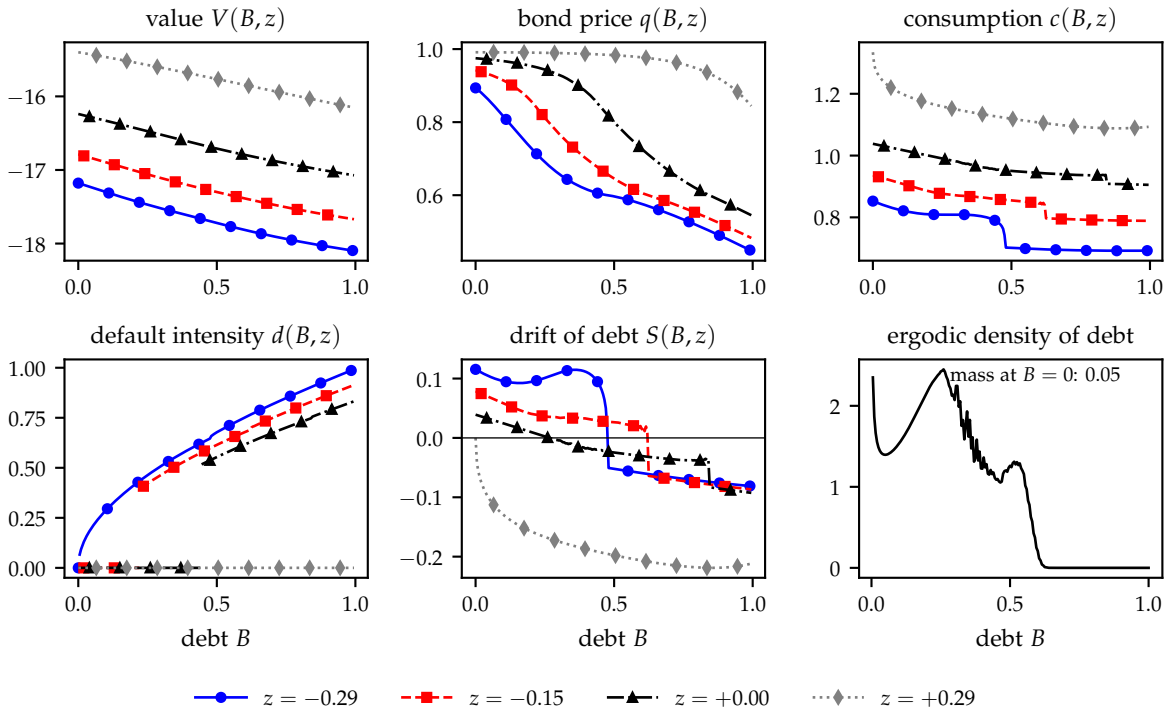


Figure 9: The diffusion model: value, bond price, consumption, default intensity, and drift of debt as functions of debt at four endowment levels, and the ergodic marginal density of debt (the atom at $B = 0$ is reported in the panel).

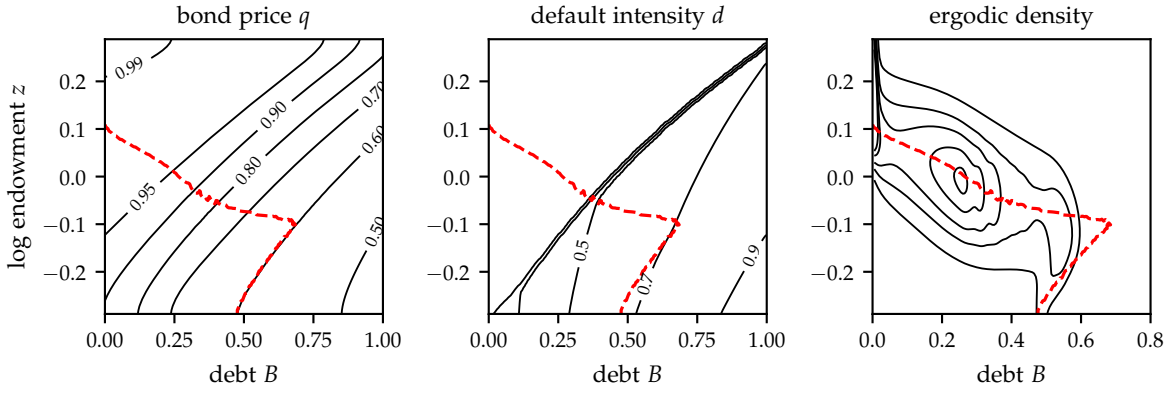


Figure 10: The diffusion model over the state space: contours of the bond price, of the default intensity, and of the ergodic density. Dashed: the zero-drift locus, where debt is stationary.

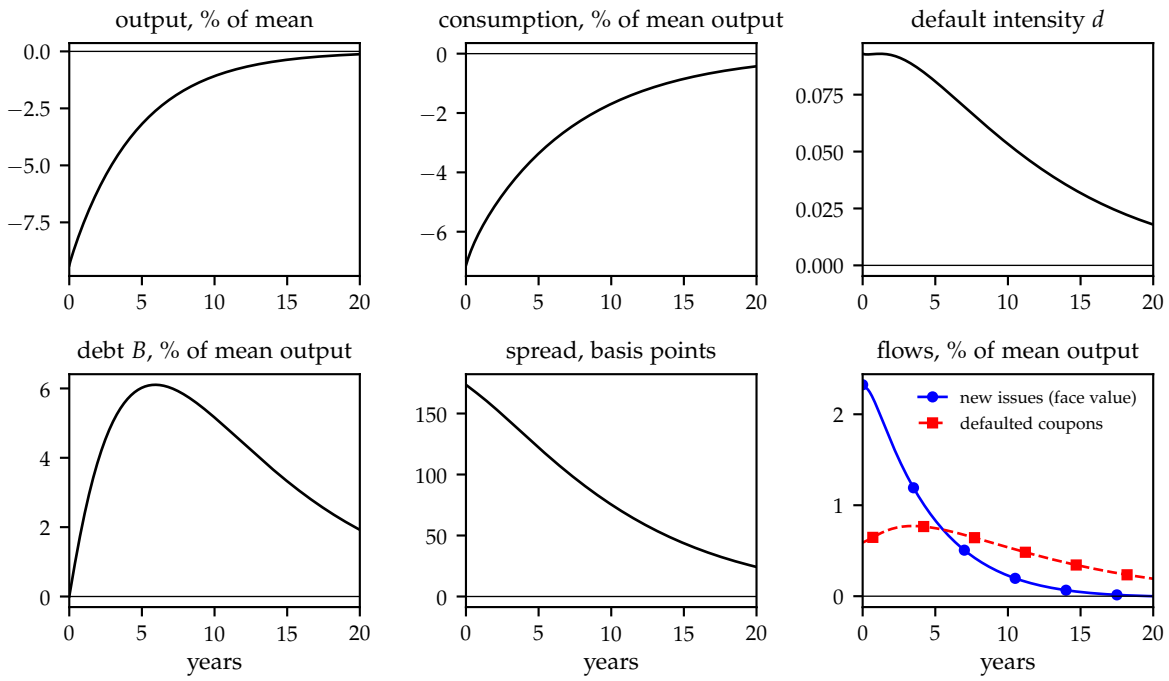


Figure 11: Impulse responses to a negative shock of 0.10 to the log endowment at date zero, from the ergodic distribution: expected path under the forward equation minus the ergodic mean. Flows are in percent of mean annual output, and the spread is in basis points.

Impulse responses. Figure 11 shows the response of the economy to a negative shock to the endowment. Starting from the ergodic distribution, we lower z by 0.10 at date zero, about one stationary standard deviation and a ten percent fall in output, and report the expected path of each variable minus its ergodic mean. The expectation is computed exactly with the forward equation of the discretized process, without simulation (Appendix B.3). Output falls on impact and recovers at the rate μ. Consumption falls by less than output and recovers more slowly, because the sovereign smooths the shock by issuing new debt and withholding debt service. The default intensity jumps on impact and stays elevated for a decade. Debt *rises* for about six years after the shock, by some six percent of annual output at the peak, before it is worked off. Up to the peak, new issues add 8.4 percent of annual output to the debt and arrears 1.6 percent, the rest of the difference being amortization. The spread rises on impact by about 174 basis points and declines as output recovers. The last panel shows the two flows behind the rise in debt, new issues in face value and defaulted coupons. New issues are the larger flow for five and a half years and decline as debt rises and the price falls. Defaulted coupons are the larger flow thereafter, while the default intensity is still elevated. The proceeds of the issues are below their face value, so as sources of funds the two flows are closer than the panel shows. These are the dynamics of partial default episodes documented by Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023): default is protracted, debt rises during the episode, and the economy exits the episode with more debt than it entered it. The sovereign in partial default remains a net issuer, and the

recovery of output, not repayment, ends the episode.

Self-fulfilling partial default. The calibration rules out the multiplicity of Section 3.3 in the deterministic model with the endowment at its mean. The stationary spread at the first default, 1,286 basis points, exceeds the floor spread of 1,278, so the standard excludes partial-default steady states (Proposition 3), if narrowly. The impatience wedge, 225 basis points, is in any case far below the risk-neutral threshold, 1,286 basis points with these default costs, so a risk-neutral sovereign would not reach such a steady state from zero debt (Proposition 4(a)). In every case we computed, curvature raised the threshold. What we have not shown is that the no-default-basin equilibrium is the only equilibrium of any shape at these parameters, or that the diffusion model admits no self-fulfilling equilibrium.

5 Conclusion

In the standard model of sovereign default, the value of market access limits how much a sovereign can borrow. A sovereign repays as long as staying in the market is worth more than defaulting into exclusion. Its debt limit is the outcome of the whole dynamic problem, shaped by its patience, its risk aversion, and the punishment that follows a default. The partial default model of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023) gives a different answer, and a simple one. Withholding part of the debt service raises funds at a price fixed by the recovery on arrears, a haircut that existing creditors bear. The terms of this source of funds do not deteriorate with the sovereign's creditworthiness, and the decision to use it is a static comparison of the funds raised with the output cost of default. A sovereign's debt capacity is then the largest debt it is willing to service in full at the risk-free price. This capacity is a closed form in the default costs, the recovery on arrears, and the maturity of the debt, independent of the sovereign's patience, its risk aversion, and the borrowing limit. Preferences decide whether a sovereign goes to its limit. The cost of defaulting decides where the limit is.

The same structure governs the anatomy of a crisis. Entry is lumpy: the fixed cost makes the first default a jump, half of the debt service at the calibrated parameters. The jump is triggered by a shock that moves the threshold below the debt a precautionary sovereign holds, not by borrowing into default. The episode is a financing regime: once the fixed cost is being paid, it no longer restrains borrowing at the margin. The debt target is set by the dilution of the sovereign's own price, and the sovereign keeps borrowing, adding more to its debt through new issues than through arrears. Exit comes when output recovers and the threshold rises back above the debt, not when the debt is repaid, which is why countries leave default episodes owing more than when they entered them. A sovereign above its capacity, in contrast, works its debt down gradually, along a cube-root law, and its price responds at once. Pessimism alone can also start a crisis. A price that anticipates a permanent partial default makes withholding cheap enough to validate itself, provided the gain from front-loading the funds the sovereign raises covers

the output cost of the default. The sovereign then drifts into default over years, without a run or a loss of market access. For a risk-neutral sovereign this condition is necessary and nearly sufficient. Curvature raises the bar, and the calibrated model is far from meeting it.

These results rest on a formulation that also simplifies computation. Because the sovereign never loses market access, there is no stopping problem. A single Hamilton–Jacobi–Bellman equation and a single linear pricing equation describe the equilibrium at every state, and the default rule is explicit given the price. The deterministic model reduces to a pair of ordinary differential equations whose behavior at capacity we characterize in closed form and confirm on computed solutions. The stochastic models are solved by an implicit upwind scheme that updates the value and the price jointly and treats the non-concavity created by the fixed cost directly. No taste shocks or other smoothing of the default and borrowing decisions are needed, and the computed decision is the one the model describes. Moments that are functions of the state and the impulse responses come from the generator of the discretized process rather than from simulation, and a parameter evaluation takes minutes. Calibrated to the targets of Arellano, Mateos-Planas, and Ríos-Rull (2023), with their weights, the model fits them at least as well as the original, with a loss of 0.077 against 0.228. Making the borrowing limit explicit also brings out a problem that quantitative models leave implicit in the top of the debt grid, the accumulation of debt where default carries no fixed cost. The underwriting standard removes it while binding on less than one percent of the ergodic mass.

Several avenues remain. On the theoretical side, self-fulfilling partial default is nearly settled for a risk-neutral sovereign, up to an attraction and a continuation condition. With curvature or shocks we have computed the threshold but not proved it, and a proof would complete the account of slow-moving debt crises with arrears. With shocks we have also studied only steady debts that do not move with the endowment, and we have studied curvature and uncertainty only one at a time. Existence of the coupled equilibrium in the stochastic models is open, and so is the behavior of the model at high debt without a borrowing limit. On the quantitative side, the implicit price of arrears is set by the recovery parameter and does not respond to the market. A model in which the recovery is the outcome of a renegotiation would make that price depend on the state, and data on arrears and their eventual treatment could discipline it. The spread tracks output and debt more tightly than in the data because the lenders' side carries no shocks, so shocks to the lenders' side are the first extension the fit calls for. The others, a measure of small open economies exposed to common global shocks, reserves, or a maturity composition, all carry larger state spaces. A tensor grid becomes expensive with a third state and infeasible with a fourth, so methods for larger state spaces are the natural next step on the computational side. Such methods can exploit the closed-form policies and the concentration of the stationary distribution around the thresholds.

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Appendix to "Debt Capacity and the Anatomy of Sovereign Crises"

by Sangdong Kim and Gabriel Mihalache

A Additional Results, Proofs, and Derivations

A.1 Derivations

Derivation of the HJB equation (6). Over a short interval Δt the principle of optimality gives $V(B_0, z_0) = \max\{u(c_0)\Delta t + e^{-\rho\Delta t}\mathbb{E}_0 V(B_{\Delta t}, z_{\Delta t})\}$. Expanding, $\mathbb{E}_0 V(B_{\Delta t}, z_{\Delta t}) = V + V_B\, S\, \Delta t + \mathcal{L}_z V\, \Delta t + o(\Delta t)$, where $\mathcal{L}_z$ is the generator of z (zero for constant z, $\sum_{k\neq j}\eta_{jk}[V(B, z_k) - V(B, z_j)]$ for a chain, $-\mu z V_z + \frac{1}{2}\sigma^2 V_{zz}$ for the diffusion). Dividing by Δt and letting $\Delta t \to 0$ gives (6).

Derivation of the pricing equation (10). Over $[t, t+\Delta t]$ a unit of debt pays $(1-d_t)(\delta+\lambda)\Delta t$, matures at rate δ, grows by the arrears $\kappa(\delta+\lambda)d_t\Delta t$, and is discounted at r, so $q_t = (1-d_t)(\delta+\lambda)\Delta t + e^{-\xi(d_t)\Delta t}\,\mathbb{E}_t q_{t+\Delta t} + o(\Delta t)$ with $\xi(d) = r + \delta - \kappa(\delta+\lambda)d$. The same expansion gives (10); integrating gives (9).

Derivation of the forward equation (11). For a test function f, $\frac{d}{dt}\mathbb{E}f(B_t, z_t) = \mathbb{E}[\tilde{S} f_B + \mathcal{L}_z f]$, and writing the expectation against the density g and integrating by parts gives $\partial_t g = -\partial_B[\tilde{S} g] + \mathcal{L}_z^* g$, with $\mathcal{L}_z^* g = \partial_z[\mu z g] + \frac{1}{2}\sigma^2\partial_{zz} g$ in the diffusion model. The discrete analogue is exact: if A is the generator matrix of the discretized process, the stationary distribution solves $A^\top g = 0$.

A.2 Results and Proofs for Section 3.1

This subsection proves the results of Section 3.1, and states and proves the four properties of the price and the value summarized there.

Proof of Lemma 1. With $\ell = n - \kappa(\delta+\lambda)dB$, (1) gives $c = \phi e^z - (1-d)(\delta+\lambda)B + qn - \kappa q(\delta+\lambda)dB = \phi e^z - (\delta+\lambda)B + qn + (1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)Bd$. At a given drift S, $n = S + \delta B$, so $c = \mathcal{R}(d) + qS$ with $\mathcal{R}$ as stated, and $\mathcal{R}_d$ follows from (3). □

Proof of Proposition 1. Fix any admissible drift S. The objective $u(\mathcal{R}(d) + qS) + SV_B$ depends on d only through $\mathcal{R}(d)$, u is increasing, and the feasibility constraint $c \geq c_{\min}$ is relaxed by a larger $\mathcal{R}(d)$. Hence for every S the best d maximizes $\mathcal{R}$, and so does the d-component of the joint maximizer. □

Proof of Proposition 2. On $(0,1]$, $\mathcal{R}'(d) = -\gamma_0\gamma_1 F(z)e^z d^{\gamma_1 - 1} + (1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)B$ is strictly decreasing with $\mathcal{R}'(0^+) > 0$, so $\mathcal{R}$ is strictly concave with maximizer d_{int} of (8). The gain from defaulting is $\mathcal{R}(d_{\text{int}}) - \mathcal{R}(0) = \Gamma(B, z, q) - (1 - F(z))e^z$, which gives (13). Since d_{int} maximizes $(1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)Bd - \gamma_0 F(z)e^z d^{\gamma_1}$ on $[0,1]$, the envelope theorem gives $\partial_B\Gamma = (1-\kappa q)(\delta+\lambda)d_{\text{int}} >$

0 and $\partial_q \Gamma = -\kappa(\delta+\lambda)B d_{\text{int}} < 0$ for $B > 0$, whether d_{int} is interior or capped, and $\Gamma = 0$ at $B = 0$; (a), (b), and (d) follow. At $B = B_{\text{fd}}(z,q)$, where $d_{\text{int}} = 1$, $\Gamma = (\gamma_1 - 1)\gamma_0 F(z) e^z$, so $B_{\text{pd}} < B_{\text{fd}}$ if and only if $1 - F(z) < (\gamma_1 - 1)\gamma_0 F(z)$, that is $d_{\text{first}} < 1$. Eliminating B between $\Gamma = (1-F)e^z$ and (8) gives (14), and eliminating d_{int} gives (15); when $d_{\text{first}} \geq 1$ the jump is from 0 to 1, and $\mathcal{R}(1) = \mathcal{R}(0)$ gives the second formula. □

Proposition A.1 (the bond price)**.** *In the general model, fix measurable policies (d, S), let (B_t, z_t) be the induced process, and define q by (9), the bounded solution of (10) wherever that equation holds. Then $0 \leq q \leq q^{\text{rf}}$; $q(B,z) = q^{\text{rf}}$ if and only if $d_t = 0$ for almost every t, almost surely, along the path from (B,z); and $q(B,z) = 0$ if and only if $d_t = 1$ for almost every t, almost surely.*

Proof of Proposition A.1. (9) is the Feynman–Kac representation of (10) with discount rate $\xi(d_t) \geq \xi(1) > 0$. The bound: $(1-d)(\lambda+\delta) \leq q^{\text{rf}}\xi(d)$ for all $d \in [0,1]$ is equivalent to $d\,\xi(1) \geq 0$; integrating, $q \leq q^{\text{rf}}\,\mathbb{E}\int_0^\infty \xi(d_t) e^{-\int_0^t \xi} dt = q^{\text{rf}}$, with equality iff $d_t = 0$ for almost every t, almost surely. The integrand of (9) is nonnegative and vanishes exactly where $d_t = 1$, so $q = 0$ if and only if $d_t = 1$ for almost every t, almost surely. □

Proposition A.2 (continuity of the price along crossing flows)**.** *In the deterministic, chain, and diffusion models, fix a state (B_0, z_0) and suppose that on a neighborhood of it the equilibrium drift is negative and bounded away from zero, so that from every nearby state debt moves down through B_0 in a time that vanishes with the distance to B_0. Then $q(\cdot, z_0)$ is continuous at B_0: with no further condition in the deterministic and chain models, and in the diffusion model whenever $q(B,\cdot)$ is continuous at z_0 uniformly in B on a neighborhood of B_0. The same holds with positive drift. Hence q can be discontinuous in B only at points where the drift vanishes or changes sign that are not reached in finite time from both sides (and, in the diffusion model, where q is not continuous in z).*

At a stationary point of debt that is approached from below and left from above, the paths on the two sides go to different places, Proposition A.2 does not apply, and the price can jump.

Proof of Proposition A.2. With the drift bounded away from zero, from $(B_0 + x, z_0)$ debt reaches B_0 at a time $\tau(x) \to 0$ on every path along which z stays in the neighborhood. By (9) and the strong Markov property, $q(B_0+x, z_0) = \mathbb{E}\left[\int_0^\tau e^{-\int_0^t \xi}(1-d)(\lambda+\delta)\,dt + e^{-\int_0^\tau \xi}\, q(B_\tau, z_\tau)\right]$. The integral is $O(\tau)$ and the discount factor tends to one. In the deterministic model $(B_\tau, z_\tau) = (B_0, z_0)$. For a chain, z switches before τ with probability $O(\tau)$, and on the complement $(B_\tau, z_\tau) = (B_0, z_0)$; since q is bounded, the expectation tends to $q(B_0, z_0)$. For the diffusion, z leaves the neighborhood before τ with vanishing probability and otherwise $B_\tau = B_0$ with $z_\tau - z_0 = O_p(\tau^{1/2})$, so the expectation tends to $q(B_0, z_0)$ when $q(B_0, \cdot)$ is continuous at z_0. This gives continuity from the right. From the left, start at (B_0, z_0) itself: debt reaches $B_0 - x$ at a time $\tau(x) \to 0$, and the same decomposition gives $q(B_0, z_0) = O(\tau) + \mathbb{E}\left[e^{-\int_0^\tau \xi}\, q(B_0 - x, z_\tau)\right]$. In the deterministic and chain models $z_\tau = z_0$ with probability $1 - O(\tau)$, so $q(B_0 - x, z_0) \to q(B_0, z_0)$. In the diffusion model $q(B_0 - x, z_\tau) - q(B_0 - x, z_0) \to 0$ in probability by the uniform continuity in z, and the same conclusion follows. With positive drift the two sides exchange roles. □

Proposition A.3 (autarky and its removal)**.** *In the general model with z in a bounded set: under a zero price, full default is optimal if and only if B is at least $B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z,0)$ and above $B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,0)$, and, without the underwriting standard, $(q \equiv 0, d \equiv 1)$ is an equilibrium of the model restricted to any invariant set contained in $\{B \geq \max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z,0), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,0)\}\}$, a knife edge. Invariance requires the sovereign to issue at least aB at a zero price. Under the convention that no bonds are traded at a zero price, $q > 0$ at every state in every equilibrium.*

Proof of Proposition A.3. The default rule under $q = 0$ is Proposition 1 with $q = 0$. With $q = 0$ issuance does not enter the budget, so any ℓ is optimal. With $d = 1$ no payment is made and $q = 0$ is the lenders' valuation. Invariance is needed for self-consistency, and with $d = 1$ debt decays at rate a unless $\ell \geq aB$. For the removal: suppose $q(B_0, z_0) = 0$. By Proposition A.1, $d = 1$ a.e. along the path, so $q = 0$ along the path, so $\ell = 0$ along the path and $B_t = B_0 e^{-at}$. Since $B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z,0) = \gamma_0\gamma_1 F(z)e^z/(\delta+\lambda)$ is bounded below by a positive constant on a bounded set of z, so is $\max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z,0), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,0)\}$, and in finite time B_t falls below $\inf_z \max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z,0), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,0)\}$. There full default is not optimal. With no issuance at a zero price, consumption is $\phi(d,z)e^z - (1-d)(\delta+\lambda)B$ and debt decays at rate $a(d)$. Lowering d for an instant, slightly below 1 if $B < B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z,0)$, where $\mathcal{R}_d(1; B, z, 0) < 0$, or to 0 if $B < B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,0)$, raises consumption now and lowers debt, while returning to $d = 1$ afterwards gives the same consumption $(1-\gamma_0)F(z)e^z$ whatever the debt. The deviation is strictly better, a contradiction. □

The next result gives the sign of V_B that Proposition A.6 uses.

Proposition A.4 (the value is nonincreasing in debt)**.** *In the general model, if for every z the price $q(\cdot, z)$ is nonincreasing and strictly positive, and the drift cap is slack along the optimal path and along the mimicking path of the proof, then $V(\cdot, z)$ is nonincreasing, with or without buybacks and with or without the underwriting standard.*

Proof of Proposition A.4. Let $B' < B$ and let (d_t, ℓ_t) be the realized default and issuance path of the optimal policy from (B, z) along the realized z-path, with debt B_t. The sovereign at B' runs the same default path and the issuance $\ell'_t = \ell_t$ if $\ell_t \geq 0$, $\ell'_t = \ell_t\, q(B_t, z_t)/q(B'_t, z_t)$ if $\ell_t < 0$ (the same bonds when issuing, the same expenditure when buying back). The override $\ell'_t = 0$ applies if $B'_t = 0$ and $\ell_t < 0$. First, $B'_t \geq 0$ at all dates: at $B'_t = 0$ the rule gives $\ell'_t \geq 0$, hence $\dot{B}'_t = \ell'_t - a(d_t)B'_t \geq 0$. Next, the gap $b_t = B_t - B'_t$ solves $\dot{b} = (\ell_t - \ell'_t) - a(d_t)b$, with $b_0 > 0$. If b were negative on some interval $(t_2, t_1]$ with $b(t_2) = 0$, then on it $B'_t > B_t \geq 0$, so the override is inactive, and $q(B'_t, z_t) \leq q(B_t, z_t)$ because the price is nonincreasing. Hence $\ell'_t = \ell_t$ when $\ell_t \geq 0$ and $\ell'_t \leq \ell_t$ when $\ell_t < 0$, so $\ell_t - \ell'_t \geq 0$. With $-a(d_t)b > 0$ this gives $\dot{b} > 0$ on the interval and $b(t_1) > 0$, a contradiction. Hence $0 \leq B'_t \leq B_t$: the state constraints hold, and the standard is respected because $q(B'_t, z_t) < \underline{q}$ implies $q(B_t, z_t) < \underline{q}$, hence $\ell_t \leq 0$ and $\ell'_t \leq 0$. Consumption satisfies $c'_t - c_t = (1-d_t)(\delta+\lambda)b_t + [q(B'_t, z_t)\ell'_t - q(B_t, z_t)\ell_t] \geq 0$. The bracket is 0 when $\ell_t < 0$, $\ell_t[q(B'_t, z_t) - q(B_t, z_t)] \geq 0$ when $\ell_t \geq 0$, and $-q(B_t, z_t)\ell_t > 0$ when the override is active ($B'_t = 0$ and $\ell_t < 0$). The default costs coincide, so the mimicking path gives the sovereign at B' at least the utility of the optimal path from B. □

A.3 The Model at High Debt

Two things happen in the model at high debt. The first is the knife-edge autarky equilibrium of Proposition A.3, which a convention removes. The second is an accumulation of debt into the borrowing limit where default carries no fixed cost, which we describe here and remove with the underwriting standard. The discrete-time literature encounters these two together with a third, numerical one, a resolution artifact of first-order schemes that mimics a second basin of attraction (Appendix B.3). At the parameters of Table 1 only the lowest node of the endowment grid lies below the fixed-cost threshold. Without the standard the accumulation is present but carries a negligible share of the ergodic mass, and once the standard is imposed it binds in partial default only (Section 4.3 and Appendix C).

Accumulation without a fixed cost. The mechanism is an argument. In the no-fixed-cost region a sovereign in full default pays nothing, bears only the variable cost, and faces a marginal cost of debt $-V_B$ close to zero, while the price is positive because output will recover. By (7) it issues at any positive price. Even without the borrowing limit it could not keep doing so forever: debt that stayed above every full-default threshold would never be serviced again and would be worthless, which the convention against trade at a zero price rules out (Proposition A.3).

Proposition A.5 (debt is not trapped above the full-default thresholds)**.** *In the general model with z in a bounded set Z and without the underwriting standard, drop the borrowing limit, letting debt range over $[0, \infty)$, impose the convention that no bonds are traded at a zero price, and let*

$$\hat{B} := \sup_{z \in Z} \max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z, q^{\mathrm{rf}}), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z, q^{\mathrm{rf}})\}.$$

In every equilibrium, from every state (B, z), debt falls to $\hat{B}$ or below at some date with positive probability.

So without the borrowing limit debt cannot stay above every full-default threshold forever with certainty. In the deterministic model, where paths are monotone, debt never exceeds $\max\{B_0, \hat{B}\}$. Whether an equilibrium exists then, and what it looks like at high debt, is open. With the limit, the accumulation runs into it: where default carries no fixed cost, the sovereign in full default borrows up to $\bar{B}$, whatever its level, and the limit is what stops the growth and keeps the price at high debt positive. A parameter that is normally innocuous then shapes equilibrium behavior at high debt. In models that leave the limit implicit, the top of the debt grid plays this role, and a choice about the computation becomes part of the model. The entry point of the accumulation is a stationary point approached from below (the sovereign borrows up to a self-imposed limit just below the full-default line) and left from above, so Proposition A.2 does not apply there.

The underwriting standard. With issuance switched off below $\underline{q}$, the drift beyond the full-default line is at most $-a(d)B < 0$, and the full-default line is crossed downward from both

sides. In the deterministic model the price is continuous across it whenever the drift is also negative just below it (Proposition A.2). In every model, any $\bar{B}$ above the full-default thresholds is an exact truncation (Proposition A.7). With the standard, the level of the borrowing limit is therefore irrelevant, unlike without it.

What the standard does. The constraint of the standard, $\ell \leq 0$, depends on d through $\ell = S + a(d)B$, so the separation of Proposition 1 must be re-examined where the standard binds.

Proposition A.6 (the default decision under the standard)**.** *In the general model with the underwriting standard, fix a state with $q = q(B,z) < \underline{q}$, $B > 0$, and $V_B < 0$, and let (d^*, S^*) be the unconstrained maximizer with issuance $\ell^* = S^* + a(d^*)B$.*

(a) If $\ell^* \leq 0$ the standard is slack and Proposition 1 holds verbatim.

(b) If $\ell^* > 0$ and $d^* > 0$ (the unconstrained optimum is in partial default) the constrained maximum has $\ell = 0$, hence $S = -a(d)B$, and the default intensity maximizes

$$J(d) := u(\phi(d,z)e^z - (1-d)(\delta+\lambda)B) - a(d)\,B\,V_B.$$

At a maximizer $d^{**} \in (0,1]$, the corner $d^{**} = 1$ included, with $c^{**} := \phi(d^{**},z)e^z - (1-d^{**})(\delta+\lambda)B$,

$$d^{**} = d_{\text{int}}(B,z,\hat{q}), \qquad \hat{q} := \frac{-V_B}{u'(c^{**})} \in (0,q) :$$

the unconstrained rule (8) evaluated at the sovereign's own shadow price of a unit of debt instead of the market price. Since d_{int} is nonincreasing in the price, $d^{**} \geq d_{\text{int}}(B,z,q)$, strictly whenever $d_{\text{int}}(B,z,q) < 1$.

(c) If $\ell^* > 0$ and $d^* = 0$ (the unconstrained optimum repays in full while issuing), repaying in full forces $\ell = 0$ and gives $J(0)$, while defaulting gives at least $J(d^{**})$, with d^{**} the maximizer of J on $(0,1]$ and $\hat{q} := -V_B/u'(c^{**})$; a default may also come with a buyback, if it frees enough resources. The constrained optimum defaults whenever $B > B_{\text{pd}}(z,\hat{q})$, since J is the objective at the shadow price, and only if $B > B_{\text{pd}}(z,q_0)$, with $q_0 := -V_B/u'(e^z - (\delta+\lambda)B)$ the shadow price at full repayment. When the default branch also wants to issue, $\hat{q} < q$ and the threshold falls with the price, so the standard can induce a default that the market-price rule does not; when it would buy back, $\hat{q} > q$ and the sufficient condition is not met.

The numerical kernel maximizes over (d,S) jointly and therefore implements the constrained rule. At the parameters of Table 1, the standard binds in partial default on just under one percent of the ergodic mass. There the default intensity exceeds the market-price rule by two percent of that rule on average and by up to about four percent.

Proposition A.7 (the standard removes the accumulation)**.** *In the general model with z in a bounded set Z and the underwriting standard, in every equilibrium in which $q < \underline{q}$ at every state where the sovereign is in full default:*

(a) *in full default the drift is $S \le -aB < 0$: the full-default region is transient, and in the deterministic model, if $V_B \le 0$, it is left in time at most $a^{-1}\ln\big(B/\max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(0,0), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0,0)\}\big)$;*

(b) *in the deterministic model the drift has no zero in $\{q < \underline{q},\ B > 0\}$; a stationary point on the floor locus $\{q = \underline{q}\}$ has $q = q_r(d^\circ) = \underline{q}$, the equality case of Proposition 3, so it exists only if $q_r(d_{\mathrm{first}}) \ge \underline{q}$, and the price is continuous across it whenever it is reached in finite time from both sides;*

(c) *any borrowing limit $\bar{B} > \hat{B}$, with $\hat{B}$ as in Proposition A.5, is an exact truncation: the drift points inward at $\bar{B}$ in every endowment state and the stationary distribution puts no mass on it;*

(d) *the thresholds of Proposition 2, as functions of the state and the price, are unaffected; in the deterministic no-default-basin equilibrium with the finite-reach condition, where $q \equiv q^{\mathrm{rf}}$ on $[0, B^*]$, so are the no-default region and the steady state of Theorem 1, whenever $\underline{q} < q^{\mathrm{rf}}$. In the stochastic models a state without default can be priced below the floor, since default is expected after future shocks, and there the standard can change the default decision (Proposition A.6(c));*

(e) *the level of the borrowing limit does not affect the equilibrium on the states below it: for any two limits $\bar{B}_2 > \bar{B}_1 > \hat{B}$, the restriction to $[0, \bar{B}_1]$ of an equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_2$ is an equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_1$, and every equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_1$ in which buybacks are not optimal in full default above $\bar{B}_1$, $-V_B \le qu'(c)$ there, extends to one with limit $\bar{B}_2$.*

Proposition A.8 (the standard bounds the support of debt)**.** *In the general model with the underwriting standard, let $B^\sharp := \max\Big\{0,\ \sup\{B :\ q(B,z) \ge \underline{q} \text{ for some } z\}\Big\}$. Then in every equilibrium with any $\bar{B} \ge B^\sharp$: whenever $B_t > B^\sharp$ the drift satisfies $S_t \le -aB_t$, the set $[0, B^\sharp] \times Z$ is invariant, and every stationary distribution is supported in it.*

Under the hypothesis of Proposition A.7, $B^\sharp \le \hat{B}$, so by part (e) neither $B^\sharp$ nor the equilibrium on $[0, B^\sharp]$ depends on a limit above $\hat{B}$. Proposition A.7 concerns limits above the full-default thresholds of every endowment state, whereas Proposition A.8 holds for any limit. The computations use a lower limit, $\bar{B} = 1$, below the full-default thresholds at the risk-free price in every state, so there the irrelevance of the limit is a numerical finding. In the diffusion model at the calibrated parameters, the sovereign chooses an inward drift at high debt in every state, the top of the grid carries no mass, and moving the limit from 1 to 1.5 leaves the moments unchanged (Table 3).

Proofs.

Proof of Proposition A.5. Suppose that from (B_0, z_0) debt stays above $\hat{B}$ at every date almost surely. Without the standard the default decision is the static rule of Propositions 1 and 2 at every date. The thresholds B_{pd} and B_{fd} are nondecreasing in the price and $q \le q^{\mathrm{rf}}$ (Proposition A.1), so $B_t > \hat{B} \ge \max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(z_t, q_t), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z_t, q_t)\}$ and the sovereign is in full default at every date (Proposition 2(d)). No payment is ever made along the path, and (9) gives $q(B_0, z_0) = 0$, which contradicts Proposition A.3, whose argument does not use the upper bound $\bar{B}$. $\hat{B}$ is finite because the thresholds are continuous in z on the bounded set Z. □

Proof of Proposition A.6. Parametrize the choice by (d, ℓ). The objective is $\mathcal{G}(d,\ell) = u(\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(d) + q\ell) + (\ell - a(d)B)V_B$ with $\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(d) = \phi(d,z)e^z - (1-d)(\delta+\lambda)B$ the resource function at a zero price, and the constraint is $\ell \le 0$, which no longer involves d. On $(0,1]\times\mathbb{R}$, $\tilde{\mathcal{R}}$ is concave in d, u is concave and increasing, and the last term is linear, so $\mathcal{G}$ is jointly concave. (a) is immediate. For (b), let (d_c, ℓ_c) be a constrained maximizer on the $d > 0$ branch with $\ell_c < 0$. The segment from it to (d^*, ℓ^*) crosses $\{\ell = 0\}$ at a point at which, by concavity, $\mathcal{G}$ is at least $\min\{\mathcal{G}(d_c,\ell_c), \mathcal{G}(d^*,\ell^*)\} = \mathcal{G}(d_c,\ell_c)$, so that point is a constrained maximizer with $\ell = 0$ on the $d > 0$ branch. The $d = 0$ branch is treated separately, since $\mathcal{G}$ is not concave across the fixed-cost jump at $d = 0$. Its own unconstrained maximizer has issuance $\ell_0^* > \ell^* > 0$, because $d^* > 0$ maximizes $\mathcal{R}$ and $a(d^*) < \delta$. So the same comparison along $\{d = 0\}$ gives $\ell = 0$ there as well, and the constrained optimum is the better of $J(d^{**})$ and $J(0)$. It is $J(d^{**})$: the concavity bound in the proof of (c) below gives $J(d^{**}) - J(0) \ge u'(c^{**})[\mathcal{R}(d^{**}; B, z, \hat{q}) - \mathcal{R}(0; B, z, \hat{q})] > 0$, since $B > B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,q) \ge B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z,\hat{q})$. On $\{\ell = 0\}$, $c = \tilde{\mathcal{R}}(d)$ and $S = -a(d)B$, which gives J. At an interior maximizer $J'(d) = u'(c)\tilde{\mathcal{R}}'(d) + \kappa(\delta+\lambda)BV_B = 0$, that is $\tilde{\mathcal{R}}'(d) = \kappa(\delta+\lambda)B\hat{q}$, the first-order condition of $\mathcal{R}(\cdot; B, z, \hat{q})$. At the corner $d^{**} = 1$, $J'(1) \ge 0$, that is $\tilde{\mathcal{R}}'(1) \ge \kappa(\delta+\lambda)B\hat{q}$, which is $d_{\mathrm{int}}(B, z, \hat{q}) = 1$. In both cases $d^{**} = d_{\mathrm{int}}(B, z, \hat{q})$, and the comparison with $d_{\mathrm{int}}(B, z, q)$ follows from $\hat{q} < q$ and the monotonicity of (8), which is strict below the cap. Finally $\partial_\ell \mathcal{G}(d^{**}, 0) = qu'(c^{**}) + V_B > 0$ because the constraint binds strictly, which is $\hat{q} < q$, and $\hat{q} > 0$ because $V_B < 0$ by hypothesis. For (c), on the $d = 0$ branch the unconstrained issuance is $\ell^* > 0$, so the comparison of (b) along $\{d = 0\}$ gives $\ell = 0$ and the value $J(0)$. On the $d > 0$ branch the unconstrained issuance can have either sign. If it is positive, the argument of (b) gives $\ell = 0$ and the branch value $J(d^{**})$. If it is nonpositive, the constraint is slack on the branch, and its value $\max_{d\in(0,1],\ell\le 0} \mathcal{G}(d,\ell)$ is at least $\mathcal{G}(d^{**}, 0) = J(d^{**})$. Either way the best default is worth at least $J(d^{**})$. By the concavity of u, $J(d^{**}) - J(0) \ge u'(c^{**})\big[\tilde{\mathcal{R}}(d^{**}) - \tilde{\mathcal{R}}(0)\big] + \kappa(\delta+\lambda)d^{**}BV_B = u'(c^{**})[\mathcal{R}(d^{**}; B, z, \hat{q}) - \mathcal{R}(0; B, z, \hat{q})]$. Since $d^{**} = d_{\mathrm{int}}(B, z, \hat{q})$ maximizes $\mathcal{R}(\cdot; B, z, \hat{q})$ on $(0, 1]$, the bracket is positive whenever $B > B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z, \hat{q})$ (Proposition 2), so the constrained optimum defaults there. The condition is sufficient, not necessary: the bound uses the concavity of u, and the default region under the standard can extend slightly below $B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z, \hat{q})$. For the necessary condition, let $c_0 := e^z - (\delta+\lambda)B$ and $q_0 := -V_B/u'(c_0)$. The unconstrained issuance at $d = 0$ is positive, so $q > q_0$. By the concavity of u at c_0, $\mathcal{G}(d,\ell) - \mathcal{G}(0,0) \le u'(c_0)[\mathcal{R}(d; B, z, q_0) - \mathcal{R}(0; B, z, q_0)] + \ell\, u'(c_0)(q - q_0)$, whose last term is nonpositive for $\ell \le 0$, so a default can be optimal only if $B > B_{\mathrm{pd}}(z, q_0)$. In the buyback case the default branch's optimum has $\ell < 0$, so $\partial_\ell \mathcal{G}(d^{**}, 0) < 0$, that is $\hat{q} > q$. □

Proof of Proposition A.7. (a) With $d = 1$ and $\ell \le 0$, $S = \ell - aB \le -aB$; integrate. Where the standard is slack, full default requires $B \ge B_{\mathrm{fd}}(0, q)$ and $B > B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q)$; where it binds, any default requires $B > B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q_0)$ and full default requires $B \ge B_{\mathrm{fd}}(0, \hat{q})$ (Proposition A.6), with $q_0, \hat{q} \ge 0$ because $V_B \le 0$. All these thresholds are nondecreasing in the price, so in the deterministic model debt has left the full-default region by the time it falls below $\max\{B_{\mathrm{fd}}(0,0), B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0,0)\}$. (b) In $\{q < \underline{q}\}$ the drift is $S \le -a(d)B \le -aB < 0$ for every d, so there is no zero there. A stationary

point B° on the floor locus has $q = \underline{q}$ by definition and $q = q_r(d^\circ)$ by (9) with constant d°, and Proposition 3 gives $q_r(d_{\text{first}}) \geq q_r(d^\circ)$. If the paths from the two sides reach it in finite time, the Feynman–Kac value (9) from either side converges to the value at the point, as in the proof of Proposition A.2. (c) At $\bar{B}$ the sovereign is in full default, hence $S < 0$ there in every state, and a state with inward drift carries no stationary mass. (d) The thresholds of Proposition 2 are functions of (B, z, q) and do not involve the restriction. In the no-default-basin equilibrium $q \equiv q^{\text{rf}}$ on $[0, B^*]$ by Theorem 1, and the restriction binds only where $q < \underline{q} < q^{\text{rf}}$, so it is slack on the basin and on a right neighborhood of B^*, where q is continuous. (e) Above $\hat{B}$ the sovereign is in full default in every state at any price $q \leq q^{\text{rf}}$. Where the standard is slack, this follows from Proposition 2(d), since the thresholds are nondecreasing in the price. Where it binds, it follows from Proposition A.6, since d_{int} is decreasing in the price, the shadow price is below q, and defaulting beats repaying at the shadow price above $B_{\text{pd}}(z, q^{\text{rf}})$. In full default the price is below the floor by hypothesis, so $\ell \leq 0$ and every feasible drift satisfies $S \leq -aB < 0$. Hence from any state with $B \leq \bar{B}_1$ no feasible path, under either limit, rises above $\max\{B, \hat{B}\} \leq \bar{B}_1$, and the constraint $B \leq \bar{B}_1$ never restricts the sovereign. Given the price on $[0, \bar{B}_1]$, the feasible paths from them, and with them the value and the optimal policies, are the same under both limits. The price on $[0, \bar{B}_1]$, the Feynman–Kac value (9) along paths that stay in $[0, \bar{B}_1]$, is the same as well. So the restriction of an equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_2$ is an equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_1$. Conversely, given an equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_1$, define the value on $(\bar{B}_1, \bar{B}_2]$ as that of the problem in which the sovereign, in full default, chooses $\ell \leq 0$ until debt reaches $\bar{B}_1$, which it does in time at most $a^{-1} \ln(\bar{B}_2/\bar{B}_1)$, and then continues with the value of the given equilibrium. Define the price there by (9) along the optimal paths, $q(B, z) = \mathbb{E}\left[e^{-\xi(1)\tau} q(\bar{B}_1, z_\tau)\right]$, where $\tau = a^{-1} \ln(B/\bar{B}_1)$ is the time at which debt reaches $\bar{B}_1$, since under the proviso the sovereign does not buy back and no payment is made before τ. Without the proviso, the value and the price on the extension would have to be solved jointly. This price is below the floor because $q(\bar{B}_1, \cdot) < \underline{q}$, so the standard forbids issuance there, as the construction assumes, and the extended pair is an equilibrium with limit $\bar{B}_2$. □

Proof of Proposition A.8. Debt rises only when $\ell > 0$, which the standard permits only at $q \geq \underline{q}$, hence only at $B \leq B^\sharp$. Above $B^\sharp$, $\ell \leq 0$ and $S = \ell - a(d)B \leq -aB$. The rest follows from the continuity of B_t. □

A.4 Proofs for Section 3.3

Proof of Theorem 1. From any $B \leq B^*$ the path rises to B^* and stays, with $d \equiv 0$. Then (9) gives $q = q^{\text{rf}}$, and consumption at B^* is $1 - (\delta + \lambda)B^* + \delta B^* = 1 - rB^*$ forever. At B^* the price is q^{rf} and $d = 0$ is optimal, so $B^* \leq B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$. Suppose $B^* < B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$. By finite reach and (9), $q(B^* + x) \geq e^{-(r+\delta)\tau(x)} q^{\text{rf}} \to q^{\text{rf}}$, and $B_{\text{pd}}(0, \cdot)$ is continuous and increasing, so for small x, $B^* + x < B_{\text{pd}}(0, q(B^* + x))$ and $d = 0$ at $B^* + x$. Along the path down to B^*, then, $d \equiv 0$ and $q(B^* + x) = q^{\text{rf}}$ exactly. Thus $q \equiv q^{\text{rf}}$ and $d \equiv 0$ on a neighborhood of B^*, where the sovereign

faces the constant risk-free price with no default. There, staying at B^* is not optimal because $\rho > r$. The round trip that borrows at rate $m = \iota\tau$ for a time τ and repays at the same rate for the next τ perturbs consumption by $\Delta c_t = m - rmt$ on $[0, \tau]$ and $-m - rm(2\tau - t)$ on $[\tau, 2\tau]$, with first-order gain $u'(\bar{c}) \int_0^{2\tau} e^{-\rho t} \Delta c_t \, dt = (\rho - r) u'(\bar{c}) \iota \tau^3 + O(\iota\tau^4)$ and second-order loss $O(\iota^2\tau^3)$. For small ι the gain dominates. Since V is the value of the sovereign's problem, staying at B^* is then not optimal, contradicting $S(B^*) = 0$. □

Proof of Theorem 2. Step 1: the drift vanishes. On the right branch the first-order condition is $V' = -qu'(c)$, and with $S = (c - \mathcal{R})/q$, $\mathcal{R}(B) := \max_d \mathcal{R}(d; B, 0, q(B))$, the HJB reads

$$\rho V = u(c) + w\, u'(c), \qquad w := \mathcal{R} - c = -qS \geq 0. \tag{19}$$

Let $x \downarrow 0$: $V \to u(\bar{c})/\rho$, $q \to q^{\mathrm{rf}}$ (by the finite-reach condition and (9), as in the proof of Theorem 1) and $\mathcal{R} \to \bar{c}$, because at $B^* = B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q^{\mathrm{rf}})$ the sovereign is indifferent between $d = 0$ and d_{first}. Along any sequence on which $c \to c^+$, (19) gives $u(\bar{c}) = u(c^+) - (c^+ - \bar{c})u'(c^+)$. The function $f(c) = u(c) - (c - \bar{c})u'(c) - u(\bar{c})$ has $f(\bar{c}) = 0$ and $f'(c) = -u''(c)(c - \bar{c})$, so $f > 0$ for $c \neq \bar{c}$; hence $c \to \bar{c}$, $w \to 0$, $S \to 0$, and $V'(B^{*+}) = -u'(\bar{c})$. The same argument on the left, where $V' = -u'(c)$, gives $V'(B^{*-}) = -u'(\bar{c})$.

Step 2: the exponents. Put $p := q^{\mathrm{rf}} - q$. The pricing equation gives $p' = q\Pi/w$ with $\Pi(B, q) := \xi(d^*)q - (1 - d^*)(\lambda + \delta) \to \Pi_0 > 0$. Differentiating (19), using $V' = -qu'(c)$, $c = \mathcal{R} - w$, and the envelope theorem $\mathcal{R}' = \mathcal{R}_B - \mathcal{R}_q p'$ with $\mathcal{R}_B = -(1 - d^*)(\delta + \lambda) + qa(d^*)$ and $\mathcal{R}_q = a(d^*)B$,

$$w' = \mathcal{R}_B - \mathcal{R}_q p' + \frac{u'(c)}{|u''(c)|} \frac{\mathcal{R}_q q\Pi/w - (\mathcal{R}_B + \rho q)}{w} = \frac{M(x)}{w^2} + O(1/w),$$
$$M(x) \to M := \frac{u'(\bar{c})}{|u''(\bar{c})|} a(d_{\mathrm{first}}) B^* \Pi_0.$$

Since $w \to 0$, $w^2 w' = M + o(1)$ and $w^3 = 3Mx(1 + o(1))$, that is $w = \beta x^{1/3}(1 + o(1))$ with $\beta^3 = 3M$. Then $p' = \Pi_0(1 + o(1))/w$ integrates to $p = \alpha x^{2/3}(1 + o(1))$, and $S = -w/q$, $c = \mathcal{R} - w$ give the stated laws. The second derivative $V'' = -q'u'(c) - qu''(c)c'$ is dominated by $-|u''(\bar{c})|\beta x^{-2/3}/3$.

Step 3: the regular system (existence, uniqueness, and analyticity of the branch). In the variable $\chi = x^{1/3}$ the scaled unknowns $Q = (q^{\mathrm{rf}} - q)/\chi^2$ and $\Sigma = -qS/\chi$ solve an analytic system of Briot–Bouquet type. With $p = \chi^2 Q$, $w = \chi\Sigma$, and $d/dx = (3\chi^2)^{-1} d/d\chi$,

$$\chi Q_\chi = \frac{3q\Pi}{\Sigma} - 2Q, \qquad \chi\Sigma_\chi = \frac{3u'}{|u''|} \frac{\mathcal{R}_q q\Pi}{\Sigma^2} - \Sigma - 3\chi \left[\frac{u'}{|u''|} \frac{\mathcal{R}_B + \rho q}{\Sigma} + \frac{\mathcal{R}_q q\Pi}{\Sigma} \right] + 3\chi^2 \mathcal{R}_B,$$

with the coefficients evaluated at $c = \mathcal{R}(B^* + \chi^3, q^{\mathrm{rf}} - \chi^2 Q) - \chi\Sigma$ and $(B^* + \chi^3, q^{\mathrm{rf}} - \chi^2 Q)$. For CRRA utility and $d_{\mathrm{first}} \in (0, 1)$ all coefficients are analytic near $(0, \alpha, \beta)$. At $\chi = 0$ the right-hand sides vanish exactly at (α, β) and their Jacobian is $\begin{pmatrix} -2 & -3\Pi_0/\beta^2 \\ 0 & -3 \end{pmatrix}$ (the $(2,2)$ entry is

$-6(u'/|u''|)a(d_{\text{first}})B^*\Pi_0/\beta^3 - 1 = -3$ by the definition of β). Neither eigenvalue is a positive integer, so the Briot–Bouquet theorem (Briot and Bouquet 1856; Hille 1976, Chapter 12) yields a unique solution analytic at $\chi = 0$ with the prescribed value. Since both eigenvalues are negative, every other solution of the linearized system behaves like χ^{-2} or χ^{-3} and is unbounded as $\chi \downarrow 0$, which is the sense in which the branch is unique. The nonlinear system leads there too: in $s = \ln\chi$ the Σ equation gives $d(\Sigma^3 - 3M)/ds = -3(\Sigma^3 - 3M) + O(\chi)$, so every branch with $\Sigma > 0$ that stays bounded as $\chi \downarrow 0$ converges to (α, β), where the linearization applies.

Step 4: the second-order coefficients. The analytic solution has $Q = \alpha + Q_1\chi + O(\chi^2)$ and $\Sigma = \beta + \Sigma_1\chi + O(\chi^2)$. In the coefficients of the system, Π, $\mathcal{R}_q$, $\mathcal{R}_B$, q, and d^* differ from their values Π_0, $a(d_{\text{first}})B^*$, $R_B := -(1 - d_{\text{first}})(\delta + \lambda) + q^{\text{rf}}a(d_{\text{first}})$, q^{rf}, and d_{first} at (B^*, q^{rf}) by $O(\chi^2)$, while $\psi(c) = u'(c)/|u''(c)|$ is evaluated at $c = \bar{c} - \beta\chi + O(\chi^2)$, so $\psi = \psi(\bar{c}) - \psi'(\bar{c})\beta\chi + O(\chi^2)$. Collecting the terms of order χ in the Σ equation, with $3\psi(\bar{c})a(d_{\text{first}})B^*\Pi_0 = \beta^3$, gives $\Sigma_1 = -\beta^2\psi'(\bar{c})/\psi(\bar{c}) - 3\Sigma_1 - 3\psi(\bar{c})(R_B + \rho)/\beta - 3a(d_{\text{first}})B^*\Pi_0/\beta$. This is the formula in the statement after $3a(d_{\text{first}})B^*\Pi_0/\beta = 2a(d_{\text{first}})B^*\alpha = \beta^2/\psi(\bar{c})$, $1/\psi + \psi'/\psi = u'''/|u''|$ (since $\psi'/\psi = u''/u' - u'''/u''$), and $R_B + \rho = \rho - r + \Pi_0$ (since $q^{\text{rf}} = 1$ gives $R_B = -\lambda + \Pi_0$, and $\lambda = r$). The terms of order χ in the Q equation give $Q_1 = -3\Pi_0\Sigma_1/\beta^2 - 2Q_1$. Finally $-S = w/q = \chi\Sigma\,(1 + O(\chi^2))$ and $q^{\text{rf}} - q = \chi^2 Q$. □

Proposition A.9 (existence of the no-default-basin equilibrium)**.** *In the deterministic model with the underwriting standard, let $F(0) < 1$ and $d_{\text{first}} < 1$, let u be real-analytic near $\bar{c}$, as CRRA utility is, let $\underline{q} < q^{\text{rf}}$ exceed the full-default prices, and let $B^* = B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$ and $\bar{c} = 1 - rB^*$.*

(a) The left branch. *There is a unique drift $S > 0$ on $[0, B^*)$ with $S(B^*) = 0$ that solves $SS' = rS - (\rho - r)\psi(1 - rB + S)$, $\psi := u'/|u''|$. With $q \equiv q^{\text{rf}}$, $d \equiv 0$, $c = 1 - rB + S$, and V given by $V(B^*) = u(\bar{c})/\rho$ and $V' = -u'(c)$, it satisfies the HJB and pricing equations on $[0, B^*]$, as long as $S < \bar{S}$.*

(b) The right branch. *The solution of (16) that leaves B^* along the cube-root expansion of Theorem 2 exists and is unique near B^*. Suppose its maximal continuation keeps $S^* < 0$ and $c^* > c_{\min}$ up to the full-default threshold, and that beyond it buybacks are not optimal, $-V_B \le qu'(c)$. Then it extends to all of $[B^*, \bar{B}]$. Where the standard binds before full default, on $\{q < \underline{q},\ \ell^* > 0\}$, the system switches to the constrained regime of Proposition A.6(b), $S = -a(d^{**})B$ with d^{**} at the shadow price, and consumption steps down at the switch; beyond the full-default threshold the sovereign neither issues nor buys back, debt decays as $B_t = B_0e^{-at}$, the price is the power $q(B) \propto B^{-\tilde{\zeta}(1)/a}$, and V is given by quadrature.*

(c) The equilibrium. *Under the conditions of (a) and (b), the two branches together form a no-default-basin equilibrium with the finite-reach condition on $[0, \bar{B}]$, the only one whose right branch has the cube-root asymptotics of Theorem 2. In it q is continuous on $[0, \bar{B}]$, and V is C^1 below the point where the standard starts to bind.*

Proof of Proposition A.9. (a) In the parametrization $dB/d\vartheta = S$, $dS/d\vartheta = rS - (\rho - r)\psi(1 - rB + S)$ the basin equation is a regular system, and at $(B^*, 0)$ its vector field is $(0, -(\rho - r)\psi(\bar{c})) \neq 0$, since $\rho > r$. So exactly one trajectory passes through $(B^*, 0)$, and it crosses $S = 0$ downward: for $\vartheta < 0$ it has $S > 0$ and $B < B^*$. Followed backward in ϑ, B falls while $S > 0$, and S cannot return to zero, because on $S = 0$ the field points downward, so the trajectory could only reach $S = 0$ moving forward in ϑ. The system has no rest point with $S \geq 0$, so B reaches 0 at a finite ϑ, and the trajectory is the graph of a drift $S(B) > 0$ on $[0, B^*)$, the unique one with $S(B^*) = 0$. Define c and V as in the statement. Then $\frac{d}{dB}(\rho V - u(c) - SV') = -(\rho - r)u'(c) + Su''(c)(S' - r)$, which vanishes by the basin equation, since $S(S' - r) = -(\rho - r)u'/|u''|$. By construction, $\rho V(B^*) - u(\bar{c}) = 0$. So the HJB equation holds on $[0, B^*]$ with the drift S, which is the maximizer given $V' = -u'(c)$ and $q = q^{\mathrm{rf}}$ by concavity, as long as it is below the cap. Moreover, $d = 0$ is optimal there by Proposition 2, since $B \leq B_{\mathrm{pd}}(0, q^{\mathrm{rf}})$, and $S(0) > 0$ satisfies the state constraint. Finally, every path reaches B^* in finite time (Lemma 2) and stays, without default, so (9) gives $q \equiv q^{\mathrm{rf}}$. (b) Local existence and uniqueness near B^* are Step 3 of the proof of Theorem 2, which concerns the system (16) alone. Away from B^* the system (16) is a regular ODE as long as $S^* < 0$, $c^* > c_{\min}$, and $d^* \in (0, 1)$. The HJB equation, which is implicit in V' through c^*, can be solved for V' by the implicit function theorem because its derivative in V' is $S^* \neq 0$, and $(B, q) \mapsto d^*, \mathcal{R}^*$ are smooth there. So Picard–Lindelöf continues the branch uniquely from the cube-root start up to the first point where one of these fails or the standard starts to bind. On $\{q < \underline{q}\}$ with $\ell^* > 0$ the policy is the constrained one of Proposition A.6(b), $S = -a(d^{**})B < 0$, and the HJB equation $\rho V = u(c^{**}) - a(d^{**})BV'$ together with the pricing equation is again a regular system in (V, q), continued in the same way up to the full-default threshold. At the switch, consumption drops by about $q\ell^*$ and V' may have a kink. Beyond the full-default threshold, with $\underline{q}$ above the full-default prices the sovereign cannot issue, and by hypothesis it does not buy back, so $S = -aB$. Then the pricing equation $\xi(1)q = -aBq'$ gives the power law, and $V(B) = \int_0^\tau e^{-\rho t} u((1 - \gamma_0)F(0))dt + e^{-\rho\tau} V(B_f)$ with $\tau = a^{-1} \ln(B/B_f)$, where B_f is the debt at which the default rule, at the shadow price where the standard binds, reaches full default. Continuity of q on $(B^*, \bar{B}]$ follows from Proposition A.2, as the drift is negative throughout. (c) The value is C^1 at B^*: on the left $V'(B^{*-}) = -u'(\bar{c})$, and on the right $V' = -qu'(c) \to -u'(\bar{c})$, by Step 1 of the proof of Theorem 2, which uses only the branch. So the HJB equation holds at B^* with $S = 0$, and the pieced pair solves the HJB and pricing equations on $[0, \bar{B}]$, with the policies of the two branches attaining the maximum. It is of no-default-basin type by construction. It satisfies the finite-reach condition, since by the cube-root law the time to reach B^* from $B^* + x$ is of order $x^{2/3}$. The price is continuous at B^*, which is reached in finite time from both sides, and on each branch. Uniqueness: by Theorem 1 every no-default-basin equilibrium with finite reach has its steady state at B^*. Its left branch is the unique trajectory of (a), and a right branch with the cube-root asymptotics is the unique branch of Step 3, continued uniquely as in (b). □

Lemma A.1 (local conditions at a partial-default steady state)**.** *In the deterministic model, suppose the equilibrium has a steady state B° in the interior of the partial-default region at which S and q are*

right-differentiable and V is twice right-differentiable, with $d^\circ = d^*(B^\circ, q^\circ) \in (0,1)$. Then $q^\circ = (1 - d^\circ)(\lambda + \delta)/\xi(d^\circ)$, the slope of the price is pinned by the impatience wedge,

$$-\frac{q'(B^{\circ+})}{q^\circ} = \frac{\rho - r}{a(d^\circ)B^\circ},$$

and the slope of the drift follows from the pricing equation,

$$q'(B^{\circ+})\big(S'(B^{\circ+}) - \xi(d^\circ)\big) = (\lambda + \delta)(1 - \kappa q^\circ)\,\frac{d}{dB} d_{\text{int}}(B, q(B))\Big|_{B^{\circ+}},$$

so that the steady state is attracting from above, $S'(B^{\circ+}) < 0$, if and only if the dilution term on the right exceeds $\xi(d^\circ)\,|q'(B^{\circ+})|$.

Proof of Lemma A.1. The first identity is (9) with constant d. Differentiating $\rho V = u(c) + SV'$ with $c = \mathcal{R}^* + qS$ gives $\rho V' = u'(c)(\mathcal{R}_B + \mathcal{R}_q q' + q'S + qS') + S'V' + SV''$. At $S = 0$ the two terms in S' cancel by the first-order condition $V' = -qu'(c)$, leaving $\rho V' = u'(c)(\mathcal{R}_B + \mathcal{R}_q q')$. With $V' = -qu'(c)$, $\mathcal{R}_q = a(d)B$, and $\mathcal{R}_B = -(1-d)(\delta + \lambda) + qa(d) = -rq$ by the first identity, this reads $-\rho q = -rq + a(d)Bq'$, the second identity. The third is l'Hôpital's rule applied to $q' = (\xi(d)q - (1-d)(\lambda+\delta))/S$. □

Proof of Proposition 3. At a steady state $S = 0$, so issuance is $\ell = S + a(d^\circ)B^\circ = a(d^\circ)B^\circ \geq aB^\circ > 0$, since $a(d) \geq a(1) = a > 0$. The standard (12) forbids $\ell > 0$ when $q < \underline{q}$, so $q^\circ \geq \underline{q}$. The state stays at B° with constant intensity d°, so (9) gives $q^\circ = q_r(d^\circ)$. Differentiating, $q_r'(d) = (\lambda+\delta)(\kappa(\lambda+\delta) - (r+\delta))/\xi(d)^2 < 0$, because $\kappa < 1$ and $\lambda = r$. Moreover, $d^\circ \geq d_{\text{first}}$, because the static rule never chooses an intensity in $(0, d_{\text{first}})$ (Proposition 2). Hence $\underline{q} \leq q_r(d^\circ) \leq q_r(d_{\text{first}})$. The expression for the spread uses $\xi(d) - (1-d)(\lambda+\delta) = (1-\kappa)(\lambda+\delta)d$, which holds when $\lambda = r$. □

Proposition A.10 (the risk-neutral construction)**.** *Let $u(c) = c$ and $\rho > r$ in the deterministic model, with issuance unrestricted in speed. Write $F = F(0)$ and define for $d \in [d_{\text{first}}, 1)$ the price $q_\rho(d) := (1-d)(\lambda+\delta)/(\rho + a(d))$ of a bond that defaults at rate d forever, discounted at the sovereign's rate, the debt $B(d)$, and the attraction bound $\Omega(d)$ below. Here Θ of Proposition 4 is the output cost of the default per unit of the funds raised at the steady state:*

$$B(d) := \frac{\gamma_0\gamma_1 F\, d^{\gamma_1 - 1}\,\xi(d)}{(1-\kappa)(\lambda+\delta)^2},$$
$$\Theta(d) = \frac{1 - \phi(d,0)}{q_r(d)B(d)},$$
$$\Omega(d) := \frac{s(d)\,a(d)}{(\gamma_1 - 1)\xi(d) - \kappa(\lambda+\delta)d},$$

with $\Omega(d) = \infty$ when the denominator is not positive.

(a) On any interval of debt through which the sovereign moves at a finite speed it is indifferent, $V' = -q$, and the price solves

$$q'(B) = -\frac{(\rho + a(d))\,(q - q_\rho(d))}{a(d)B}, \qquad d = d^*(B, q),$$

with drift $S = a(d)B\,\xi(d)(q_r(d) - q)/\big((\rho + a(d))(q - q_\rho(d))\big)$; debt rises if and only if $q_\rho(d) < q < q_r(d)$.

(b) Every partial-default steady state is a point $(B(d), q_r(d))$, $d \in (d_{\text{first}}, 1)$, with $q_r(d) \geq \underline{q}$ under the standard. The one with intensity d attracts from above if and only if $\rho - r < \Omega(d)$.

(c) If $\Theta(d) \leq \rho - r < \Omega(d)$ and $q_r(d) \geq \underline{q}$, and the solution of (a) through $(B(d), q_r(d))$ can be continued above it up to $\bar{B}$, beyond the full-default threshold or where the standard binds by the full-default branch or the constrained regime of Proposition A.6(b), with negative drift and $-V' \leq q$ throughout, then there is an equilibrium in which the sovereign issues $B(d)$ at once from zero debt and stays there, withholding the share d forever.

(d) $\Omega(d_{\text{first}}) > s_{\text{first}}$ if and only if $(\gamma_1 - 1)\xi(d_{\text{first}}) < \delta$. When this holds and $q_r(d_{\text{first}}) > \underline{q}$, for every wedge $\rho - r$ in $(s_{\text{first}}, \Omega(d_{\text{first}}))$ there are intensities d slightly above d_{first} that satisfy the conditions of (c) other than the continuation condition.

Proof of Proposition A.10. With $u(c) = c$ the maximized Hamiltonian is $\mathcal{R}^*(B, q) + S\,(q + V')$, linear in the drift: where $q + V' > 0$ the sovereign issues a block at once, where $q + V' < 0$ it reduces its debt as fast as it can, and a finite positive speed requires $q + V' = 0$.

(a) On an interval with $q + V' = 0$ the HJB equation reduces to $\rho V = \mathcal{R}^*(B, q(B))$. Differentiating and using the envelope theorem, $\mathcal{R}^*_q = a(d)B$, gives $-\rho q = \mathcal{R}^*_B + a(d)Bq'$ with $\mathcal{R}^*_B = -(1 - d)(\lambda + \delta) + qa(d)$, which is the stated equation because $(\rho + a)q - (1 - d)(\lambda + \delta) = (\rho + a)(q - q_\rho)$. The pricing equation $\xi(d)q = (1 - d)(\lambda + \delta) + Sq'$ gives $S = \xi(d)(q - q_r(d))/q'$, and substituting q' gives the drift. Since $\rho > r$, $q_\rho(d) < q_r(d)$, and the sign follows.

(b) At a steady state the price is $q_r(d^\circ)$ by (9), and d° is interior, so $(1 - \kappa q)(\lambda + \delta)B = \gamma_0\gamma_1 F d^{\gamma_1 - 1}$ (Proposition 2). With $(1 - \kappa q_r(d))/q_r(d) = (1 - \kappa)/(1 - d)$, this is $B = B(d)$. At $q = q_r(d)$ the equation in (a) has slope $q' = -q(\rho - r)/(a(d)B)$, the slope of Lemma A.1. Write $P(B, q) := \xi(d^*)q - (1 - d^*)(\lambda + \delta)$, so that $S = P/q'$ along the solution and $S' = P_q + P_B/q'$ at the steady state. With $P_d = (1 - \kappa q)(\lambda + \delta)$, $\partial_B d_{\text{int}} = d/((\gamma_1 - 1)B)$, and $\partial_q d_{\text{int}} = -\kappa d/((\gamma_1 - 1)(1 - \kappa q))$, we have $P_B = (1 - \kappa q)(\lambda + \delta)d/((\gamma_1 - 1)B)$ and $P_q = \xi(d) - \kappa(\lambda + \delta)d/(\gamma_1 - 1)$. If $P_q \leq 0$ then $S' < 0$; otherwise $S' < 0$ if and only if $\rho - r < P_B a(d)B/(qP_q)$, which is $\Omega(d)$ after using $(1 - \kappa q_r)(\lambda + \delta)d/q_r = s(d)$.

(c) Let $B^\circ = B(d)$ and $q^\circ = q_r(d)$. Set $q = q^\circ$ and $V(B) = V(B^\circ) + q^\circ(B^\circ - B)$ on $[0, B^\circ]$, with $\rho V(B^\circ) = \mathcal{R}^*(B^\circ, q^\circ)$, and above B° the solution of (a) and its continuation. From any $B < B^\circ$ the state moves at once to B° and stays, so the lenders' price there is q°, and the issuance is allowed because $q^\circ \geq \underline{q}$. On $[0, B^\circ]$, $q + V' = 0$, so the sovereign is indifferent among speeds and among

blocks that end at or below B°, and the HJB equation requires that standing still not be better: $D(B) := \rho V(B) - \mathcal{R}^*(B, q^\circ) \geq 0$. The function D is concave, because $\mathcal{R}^*(\cdot, q)$ is a maximum of functions affine in B. Moreover, $D(B^\circ) = 0$, and $D'(B^{\circ-}) = (\rho + a(d))\big(q_\rho(d) - q^\circ\big) < 0$. So $D \geq 0$ on $[0, B^\circ]$ if and only if $D(0) \geq 0$. Since $(1-d)(\lambda+\delta) - q^\circ a(d) = rq^\circ$, $\mathcal{R}^*(B^\circ, q^\circ) = \phi(d,0) - rq^\circ B^\circ$ and $D(0) = (\rho - r)q^\circ B^\circ - (1 - \phi(d,0))$, which is nonnegative if and only if $\rho - r \geq \Theta(d)$. A block that ends above B°, at B' on the solution of (a), yields $q(B')(B' - B) + V(B')$, which does not exceed $V(B)$ because $V' = -q$ there and q decreases. Above B°, attraction makes the drift negative near B°, and the continuation is the hypothesis. The closed form of Θ follows from $1 - \phi(d,0) = 1 - F + \gamma_0 F d^{\gamma_1}$, from $1 - F = (\gamma_1 - 1)\gamma_0 F d_{\text{first}}^{\gamma_1}$ by (14), and from $q_r(d)B(d) = \gamma_0\gamma_1 F d^{\gamma_1 - 1}(1-d)/((1-\kappa)(\lambda+\delta))$.

(d) Since $a(d) + \kappa(\lambda+\delta)d = \delta$, $\Omega(d_{\text{first}}) > s(d_{\text{first}})$ if and only if $\delta > (\gamma_1 - 1)\xi(d_{\text{first}})$, including the case of a nonpositive denominator. With $\Theta(d_{\text{first}}) = s_{\text{first}}$, from the closed form, continuity of Θ, Ω, and q_r gives, for a wedge in $(s_{\text{first}}, \Omega(d_{\text{first}}))$, an intensity d slightly above d_{first} with $\Theta(d) < \rho - r < \Omega(d)$ and $q_r(d) \geq \underline{q}$. □

Proof of Proposition 4. As in the proof of Proposition A.10, the sovereign issues a block where $q + V' > 0$ and moves at a finite speed only where $q + V' = 0$.

(a) Along a path on which debt rises, the sovereign issues blocks or moves along the solutions of Proposition A.10(a), and consecutive blocks are one block. Let B_e be the first debt level on the path at which $d^* > 0$. If the path reaches B_e along a solution of Proposition A.10(a), the price q_e there satisfies $q_e > q_\rho(0)$, for the drift to be positive just below, where $d = 0$, and $q_e \leq q_r(d_{\text{first}})$, for it to be nonnegative just above, where $d = d_{\text{first}}$. So $q_\rho(0) < q_r(d_{\text{first}})$, which is $\rho - r > s_{\text{first}} = \Theta(d_{\text{first}})$. If the path reaches B_e by a block issued from a point $B_O > 0$ of such a solution, the price is continuous at B_O, since a bond held just below B_O is carried into the block. So the landing price q_J equals the price at B_O and exceeds $q_\rho(0)$, while landing with a nonnegative drift requires $q_J \leq q_r(d_J) \leq q_r(d_{\text{first}})$. Again, $\rho - r > \Theta(d_{\text{first}})$. If the block is issued at zero debt and lands at (B_J, q_J) with intensity $d_J \in [d_{\text{first}}, 1)$, then $V(0) = q_J B_J + V(B_J)$ with $\rho V(B_J) = \mathcal{R}^*(B_J, q_J)$, and staying at zero debt forever is worth $1/\rho$, so $\mathcal{R}^*(B_J, q_J) + \rho q_J B_J \geq 1$. As $q_J \leq q_r(d_J)$, $\mathcal{R}^*(B_J, q_J) \leq \phi(d_J, 0) - rq_J B_J$, hence $(\rho - r)q_J B_J \geq 1 - \phi(d_J, 0)$. By the first-order condition for d_J, $(1 - \phi(d_J,0))/(q_J B_J) = (1 - \phi(d_J,0))(1 - \kappa q_J)(\lambda + \delta)/\left(\gamma_0\gamma_1 F d_J^{\gamma_1 - 1} q_J\right)$, which is decreasing in q_J and equals $\Theta(d_J)$ at $q_J = q_r(d_J)$. So $\rho - r \geq \Theta(d_J) \geq \Theta^*$. If the block overshoots, landing above the steady state B° that the path then descends to along a solution of Proposition A.10(a), the price is nonincreasing above B° and $V' = -q$ there. So $V(0) = q_J B_J + V(B_J) \leq q^\circ B^\circ + V(B^\circ)$ with $\rho V(B^\circ) = \phi(d^\circ, 0) - rq^\circ B^\circ$, and $V(0) \geq 1/\rho$ again gives $\rho - r \geq \Theta(d^\circ) \geq \Theta^*$.

(b) The definition of Θ gives $\Theta(d_{\text{first}}) = s(d_{\text{first}}) = s_{\text{first}}$. Write

$$\Theta(d) = \frac{(1-\kappa)(\lambda+\delta)\, N(d)}{\gamma_1(1-d)}, \qquad N(d) = d + (\gamma_1 - 1)d_{\text{first}}^{\gamma_1} d^{1-\gamma_1};$$

for $d \geq d_{\text{first}}$,

$$N'(d) = 1 - (\gamma_1 - 1)^2 (d_{\text{first}}/d)^{\gamma_1} \geq 1 - (\gamma_1 - 1)^2 \geq 0 \quad \text{when } \gamma_1 \leq 2,$$

and $1/(1-d)$ is increasing, so Θ is increasing.

(c) Set $\bar{\Omega} := \Omega(d_{\text{first}})$. Proposition A.10(d) gives intensities with $\Theta(d) < \rho - r < \Omega(d)$ and $q_r(d) \geq \underline{q}$, and Proposition A.10(c) gives the equilibrium under the continuation condition. □

A.5 Self-Fulfilling Partial Default with Shocks

The right panel of Figure 4 rests on the following construction. The sovereign is risk-neutral, $u(c) = c$, and issuance is unrestricted in speed, as in Proposition A.10. The log endowment follows the diffusion of Section 4.1. Lenders expect the sovereign to settle at a debt B° that does not depend on z, and to stay there forever. The construction gives sufficient conditions for a self-fulfilling partial default, and the region it delivers is a numerical finding, not a theorem.

The steady debt. At B° the drift is zero and the default intensity is the static choice $d^\circ(z) = d^*(B^\circ, z, q^\circ(z))$. The price solves an ordinary differential equation in z,

$$\xi(d^\circ)\, q^\circ = (1 - d^\circ)(\lambda + \delta) + \mathcal{L}_z q^\circ,$$

and the value solves $\rho V^\circ = \mathcal{R}^*(B^\circ, z, q^\circ) + \mathcal{L}_z V^\circ$. With $\sigma = 0$ these reduce to $q^\circ = q_r(d^\circ)$ and $\rho V^\circ = \mathcal{R}^*$. We index the steady debts by the intensity d of the deterministic candidate, $B^\circ = B(d)$ of Proposition A.10, and follow the root of the price equation from $q_r(d)$.

Above the steady debt. On an interval through which the sovereign moves at a finite speed it is indifferent, $V_B = -q$. Differentiating $\rho V = \mathcal{R}^*(B, z, q) + \mathcal{L}_z V$ in B, with the envelope theorem, gives the price equation of Proposition A.10(a) with a diffusion term,

$$a(d) B\, q_B = (1 - d)(\lambda + \delta) - (\rho + a(d))\, q + \mathcal{L}_z q, \qquad d = d^*(B, z, q).$$

The equation is parabolic in B, so it is integrated upward from B°. The drift follows from the pricing equation, $S\, q_B = \xi(d) q - (1 - d)(\lambda + \delta) - \mathcal{L}_z q$. The steady debt attracts debt from above if $S_B < 0$ at $B^{\circ +}$ in every state. As in Lemma A.1, this slope follows from the two equations at B°. The continuation condition is that $S < 0$ and $q_B < 0$ up to the full-default region.

Below the steady debt. A sovereign below B° issues a block that takes it to B° at the price $q^\circ(z)$. So $q(B, z) = q^\circ(z)$ and $V(B, z) = V^\circ(z) + q^\circ(z)(B^\circ - B)$. Standing still must not be better. As in the proof of Proposition A.10(c), the gap $\rho V - \mathcal{R}^* - \mathcal{L}_z V$ is concave in B and vanishes at B°. The

condition is therefore that the gap be nonnegative at zero debt in every state,

$$\mathcal{R}^*(B^\circ, z, q^\circ) + \rho\, q^\circ B^\circ - e^z - B^\circ\, \mathcal{L}_z q^\circ \geq 0.$$

With $\sigma = 0$ this is $\rho - r \geq \Theta(d)$. Finally, issuance at B° requires $q^\circ \geq \underline{q}$ in every state.

Waiting. A sovereign at zero debt could also wait for a better endowment before it issues the block. We allow this by solving the optimal-stopping problem $\min\{\rho V - e^z - \mathcal{L}_z V,\ V - V^\circ - q^\circ B^\circ\} = 0$ at zero debt. A marginal bond there is priced by $(r+\delta)q = \lambda + \delta + \mathcal{L}_z q$ where the sovereign waits, and by $q = q^\circ$ where it issues. We then check that the sovereign at B° does not prefer to buy back its debt and wait, and that standing still is not better anywhere below B°. In every case we computed, waiting either is never chosen or makes the block worse than staying debt-free in every state. The boundaries of the region are essentially those without waiting.

Computation. The endowment grid has 201 nodes on ± 3 stationary standard deviations, with reflecting boundaries. The price equation at B° is solved by Newton's method. Where Newton's method stalls at the jump of d^* from zero to d_{first}, we iterate the monotone map $q \mapsto [\xi(d^*(q)) - \mathcal{L}_z]^{-1}(1 - d^*(q))(\lambda + \delta)$ from $q = 1$. The march above B° is implicit in $\mathcal{L}_z$, with a step of 5×10^{-4}. The conditions are imposed at the interior nodes of the endowment grid, because the two reflecting nodes carry a truncation error that grows as the grid is refined. The results do not change when the grid is refined from 101 to 801 nodes. With $\sigma = 0$ the construction reproduces the conditions of Proposition A.10 at every intensity and wedge we tried. For each standard deviation we scan sixty intensities on a grid of wedges from 30 to 600 basis points, and we bisect each boundary. The lower boundary depends on how far the endowment grid extends, because the block condition binds in the worst states. With the grid at ± 2 standard deviations the region is somewhat larger.

A.6 Proofs for Section 3.4

Proof of Proposition 5. On $[0, \underline{B}]$ no state defaults and every path stays in the set, so (9) gives $q_j = q^{\text{rf}}$ there. No default at that price requires $B \leq B_{\text{pd}}(z_j, q^{\text{rf}})$ in every state (Proposition 2), so $\underline{B} \leq \min_j B_{\text{pd}}(z_j, q^{\text{rf}})$. Near B° the price is $q^{\text{rf}} = 1$ and no state defaults, so consumption in state k is $c_k = e^{z_k} - rB + S_k$, and the HJB equation of state j reads $\rho V_j = \max_S\{u(e^{z_j} - rB + S) + SV_j'\} + \sum_{k \neq j} \eta_{jk}(V_k - V_j)$. The maximand is strictly concave in S and the maximizer is interior, so with V_j twice differentiable at B° the envelope theorem gives, at B°, $\rho V_j' = -ru'(c_j) + S_j V_j'' + \sum_{k \neq j} \eta_{jk}(V_k' - V_j')$, and $S_j(B^\circ) = 0$ removes the second term. The first-order conditions $V_k' = -u'(c_k)$, valid at B° because each V_k is differentiable there and the cap and the floor are slack, turn this into (17). If c_j is the lowest consumption at B°, the right-hand side of (17) is at most zero while the left-hand side is positive, since $\rho > r$. □

Lemma A.2 (the price is nonincreasing in the default path)**.** *In the general model, let d and d' be two adapted default processes with $d'_t \le d_t$ for all t, almost surely. Then the Feynman–Kac values (9) satisfy $q(d') \ge q(d)$.*

Proof. For $\theta \in [0,1]$ let $d^\theta = d' + \theta(d - d')$ and $Q(\theta)$ the corresponding value. Differentiating under the integral and collecting the effect of d^θ_t on the payment at t and on the discounting of the stream after t (through $\xi'(d) = -\kappa(\delta+\lambda)$), $Q'(\theta) = \mathbb{E}\int_0^\infty e^{-\int_0^t \xi(d^\theta)}(\lambda+\delta)[\kappa q^\theta_t - 1](d_t - d'_t)\,dt \le 0$, since $\kappa q^\theta_t \le \kappa q^{\mathrm{rf}} \le 1$. □

Proposition A.11 (the best response preserves monotonicity in debt)**.** *In the general model, let q be nonincreasing in B and strictly positive, let the underwriting standard be slack so that the default rule is that of Proposition 1, and suppose the debt flow induced by the optimal policy under q is order preserving (two paths started at $B' < B$ with the same z-path satisfy $B'_t \le B_t$). Then the price generated by those policies through (9) is again nonincreasing in B.*

Proof. By the monotonicity of d^* in B and in q (Section 3.1) and the monotonicity of q, $d^*(B,z) = d^*(B,z,q(B,z))$ is nondecreasing in B. With order preservation, $d^*(B'_t, z_t) \le d^*(B_t, z_t)$ pathwise, and Lemma A.2 gives the claim. □

B Numerical Implementation

Discrete equations. Debt lives on a grid B_i, $i = 0, \dots, n_B - 1$, with step ΔB, and the log endowment on z_j, $j = 0, \dots, n_z - 1$. One-sided differences are $D^+V_{ij} = (V_{i+1,j} - V_{ij})/\Delta B$ and $D^-V_{ij} = (V_{ij} - V_{i-1,j})/\Delta B$. At a node, for a given one-sided derivative V_B and price q, consumption is linear in the drift at fixed d, $c(S,d) = \mathcal{R}(d) + qS$. So the Hamiltonian $u(c(S,d)) + SV_B$ is concave in S with maximizer $S = (c^* - \mathcal{R}(d))/q$, $c^* = (u')^{-1}(-V_B/q)$, clamped to the admissible interval. The interval comes from $c \ge c_{\min}$, the cap $S \le \bar{S}$ (applied also to $-S$), the sign restriction of the candidate, and the underwriting standard $S \le -a(d)B$ where $q < \underline{q}$. Over d the maximized Hamiltonian is concave on $(0,1]$ and is maximized by golden-section search (28 iterations, a tolerance of about 10^{-6} in d), with the candidates $d = 0$, $d = 1$, and the closed form (8) also evaluated. The consumption floor is $c_{\min} = 0.05\,e^z$ and the drift cap $\bar{S} = 1$, and neither binds at any reported solution. Three candidates are formed at every node, forward (D^+V, $S \ge 0$), backward (D^-V, $S \le 0$), and zero drift. The one with the largest Hamiltonian is the policy. At B_0 the backward candidate is dropped and at B_{n_B-1} the forward one (state constraints). For a concave Hamiltonian this rule reduces to the standard upwind rule. With the fixed cost of default it is the monotone extension of that rule. The z-operator is discretized with upwinding of the exogenous drift and central second differences, so that every off-diagonal coefficient is nonnegative. With A the generator built from the policy, the discrete equilibrium is the root of

$$R_V \equiv \rho V - u(c) - AV = 0, \qquad R_q \equiv \xi(d)\,q - (1-d)(\lambda+\delta) - Aq = 0, \tag{20}$$

and all convergence statements refer to $\|R_V\|_\infty$ and $\|R_q\|_\infty$ at the current (V, q) with the policy recomputed from them, never to step-to-step changes.

B.1 Deterministic Model

The deterministic solutions at the calibrated parameters (Figures 5–7, Table 4) are computed by the time stepping of Appendix B.2 with a single endowment state. The discrete system also admits an exact solution by a branching march, which we use as a check and to compute Figure 3. Nodes with $S < 0$ depend only on the node below, nodes with $S > 0$ only on the node above, and a zero-drift node on nothing. So once the steady-state node is known the system is triangular and can be solved by marching outward. (i) *Candidates.* At each node, all prices q^* solving $q^* = (1 - d^*)(\lambda + \delta)/\xi(d^*)$ with d^* the maximizer of $u(c(0, d))$ at that price are located by a scan of $(0, 1]$ with bisection; $V^* = u(c^*)/\rho$. (ii) *Local consistency.* A candidate is kept if for some root of the node above, solved in backward mode, the forward candidate at the steady-state node does not beat zero drift, and symmetrically below. (iii) *Node solve.* Given the upwind neighbor, for each trial q the HJB node equation is monotone in V and solved by bisection, and the price equation becomes a scalar function of q whose roots are all located. (iv) *Branching march.* March up and down from the candidate, keeping every root that is consistent with the previous node's choice once the new value is known. (v) *Global check.* Verify at every node that the chosen candidate attains the maximum Hamiltonian given both neighbors, and evaluate (20). A solution is accepted if the residuals are below 10^{-8}, exactly one candidate survives with no violation, and the solution on $[0, \bar{B}]$ is unchanged when $\bar{B}$ is increased. At the calibrated parameters every partial-default candidate has a price of at most $q_r(d_{\text{first}}) = 0.599$, just below the floor, so none is an equilibrium under the standard (Proposition 3). The march cannot settle the two-point problem of Section 3.3, whether a candidate partial-default steady state is reached from zero debt, because a whole family of branches enters each candidate from below. That problem, and the continuum of Section 3.3, are solved by integrating forward from zero debt.

B.2 Chain Model

The finite-state models are solved by joint implicit upwind time stepping with the policy explicit from (V^k, q^k),

$$\Big[(\rho + 1/\Delta t)I - A^k\Big] V^{k+1} = u^k + V^k/\Delta t,$$
$$\Big[\operatorname{diag}\Big(\xi(d^k)\Big) + I/\Delta t - A^k\Big] q^{k+1} = (1 - d^k)(\lambda + \delta) + q^k/\Delta t,$$

with $\Delta t = 0.01$ and both solves sparse direct. The iteration starts from the value of servicing the debt at the risk-free rate forever, $u(e^z - rB)/\rho$, and from the stationary price implied by the interior default policy at the risk-free price. It stops when $\|R_V\|_\infty < 10^{-7}$ and $\|R_q\|_\infty < 10^{-8}$. The upper end of the grid is placed where the drift is negative in every state, so that the truncation

is exact, and this placement is checked on the solution. The pricing equation uses the same generator as the HJB equation, so its transport term is upwinded with the equilibrium drift: forward at B_0, where the drift is nonnegative, and backward at B_{n_B-1}, where the state constraint makes it nonpositive. The stationary distribution solves $A^\top g = 0$ with the converged generator.

B.3 Diffusion Model

The right panel of Figure 4 uses a separate one-dimensional scheme, described in Appendix A.5.

The diffusion model uses the same time stepping on the two-dimensional grid, with the z-operator discretized as above and Neumann conditions at $\pm\bar{z}$. In the calibration each parameter evaluation runs 3,000 implicit steps of $\Delta t = 0.015$ from a warm start at the previous point, interpolated onto the new z-grid, the first from the same initial guess as the finite-state models. The reported point is the calibrated parameters re-solved on the 75-node endowment grid for a further 9,000 steps, over which the moments are stable to the third digit. Moments are computed as described in Section 4.2: exactly from $A^\top g = 0$ for state functions, and by Euler–Maruyama simulation with bilinearly interpolated policies, 100 steps per year, annual aggregation of flows, and reflecting boundaries for z, for path functionals. The impulse responses of Section 4.3 are expectations under the forward equation $\dot{g} = A^\top g$, started from the ergodic distribution pushed down in z by the shock (split linearly between neighboring nodes) and advanced with a Crank–Nicolson step of 0.01 years.

A resolution artifact. The scheme obtains V_B by differencing, with an error of about $\frac{1}{2}|V_{BB}|\Delta B$, and the drift responds to that error with a gain of $1/(q^2|u''(c)|)$: consumption responds to the ratio V_B/q and the drift is the consumption gap divided by q again. Where the *resolution ratio*

$$\frac{\frac{1}{2}|V_{BB}|\,\Delta B}{q^2\,|u''(c)|\,|S|} \tag{21}$$

exceeds about one half, the scheme cannot determine the sign of the drift, and when the scheme loses the sign it tends to produce a positive drift, which carries the state to the top of the grid. The remedy is a grid whose spacing is proportional to q^2. We report with every solution the ergodic mass on unresolved nodes, those where the ratio exceeds one half, excluding stationary nodes ($|S| \le 10^{-3}$).

C Robustness

Without the standard. At the calibrated parameters of Table 1, solved without the standard on a debt grid extending to $\bar{B} = 2$, the sovereign issues in full default in the lowest endowment states at prices up to 0.29. The ergodic mass there, however, is about 2×10^{-6}. The moments agree with those of the solution without the standard on $[0, 1]$ to within a few thousandths, and

the pricing residual stalls at 0.2. At these parameters the standard lowers the spread volatility from 0.042 to 0.035 and raises the loss from 0.065 to 0.077.

Robustness of the calibrated point under the standard. Table 3 re-solves the calibrated point from a warm start on a finer debt grid, on a non-uniform grid of the kind of Appendix B.3, and with the barrier at $B = 1.5$. With the standard in place the moments move by amounts comparable to the sampling noise of the simulated moments, the top of the grid carries no mass, and the loss is unchanged to the second digit.

Table 3: The calibrated point under the standard on other grids

Grid	Debt/y mean	Debt/y s.d.	Spread s.d.	PD freq.	PD mean	Loss	Mass top	Unresolved
main grid	0.269	0.183	0.035	0.378	0.409	0.077	0.0000	0.015
debt step halved	0.269	0.183	0.035	0.376	0.410	0.078	0.0000	0.007
non-uniform debt grid	0.269	0.183	0.035	0.375	0.410	0.078	0.0000	0.005
barrier at $B = 1.5$	0.269	0.183	0.035	0.378	0.409	0.078	0.0000	0.015

Notes: Each row re-solves the calibrated point from a warm start. Main grid: 201 debt nodes (step 0.005) on $[0, 1]$ and 75 endowment nodes; debt step halved: 401 debt nodes; non-uniform: 572 debt nodes with steps from 0.0007 to 0.004, proportional to the square of the lowest price at each debt level; all rows use 75 endowment nodes. Mass top: ergodic mass in the top tenth of the debt grid; unresolved: ergodic mass on nodes where the resolution ratio (21) exceeds one half, excluding stationary nodes ($|S| \leq 10^{-3}$).

Comparative statics. Table 4 re-solves the deterministic model across variations of the default cost, the recovery parameter, the discount rate, and the maturity around the calibrated point, by the time stepping of Appendix B.2 on 200 nodes per unit of debt on $[0, 1.2]$, and compares the closed forms of Theorem 1 with the computed solution. In every case the last node with positive drift is two nodes below the first default node, and the computed default intensity at the first default node agrees with d_{first} to within 0.004. The first default node is within one grid step of $B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$ in every case but $\kappa = 0.65$, where it lies 1.7 steps below. Correspondingly, the computed steady state lies between 1.7 and 2.6 grid steps below $B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$, and 3.7 steps below at $\kappa = 0.65$. The steady state rises with γ_0, κ, and γ_2 and falls with δ, as the closed form says. The steady state does not move with ρ: the discount rate changes only the price schedule beyond the steady state, and with it the point where the standard starts to bind. Full default is reached on the grid in two cases only.

Table 4: Comparative statics of the deterministic steady state

	Steady state		First default			Standard	Full default
Variation	$B_{\text{pd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$	computed	d_{first}	computed	$B_{\text{fd}}(0, q^{\text{rf}})$	binds from	from
Calibrated point	0.485	0.475	0.517	0.519	1.90	0.890	–
$\gamma_0 \times 0.8$	0.451	0.440	0.556	0.557	1.52	0.785	1.11
$\gamma_0 \times 1.2$	0.514	0.505	0.487	0.489	2.28	0.990	–
$\kappa = 0.45$	0.553	0.540	0.517	0.518	2.16	1.005	–
$\kappa = 0.65$	0.869	0.850	0.517	0.517	3.40	–	–
$\gamma_2 \times 0.5$	0.305	0.295	0.411	0.412	1.92	0.710	–
$\gamma_2 \times 1.5$	0.635	0.625	0.592	0.594	1.88	1.040	–
$\rho = 0.05$	0.485	0.475	0.517	0.519	1.90	0.940	–
$\rho = 0.07$	0.485	0.475	0.517	0.519	1.90	0.860	–
$\delta = 0.12$	0.584	0.575	0.517	0.519	2.28	1.020	–
$\delta = 0.22$	0.358	0.350	0.517	0.520	1.40	0.705	1.03

Notes: One parameter changed at a time from the calibrated point (Table 1), the endowment at its mean, $\underline{q} = 0.6$. "Computed" steady state: the last grid node with positive drift; "computed" first default: the default intensity at the first node with $d > 0$. Residuals 10^{-7} and 10^{-8} in all cases but one ($\delta = 0.12$), where the price residual stalled at 4×10^{-3} after 30,000 steps. "–": full default is not reached on the grid.